



Methodology

U.S. News & World Report

2025 Best Colleges

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A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors

Find out which data is used in our undergraduate rankings and what has changed.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report's 2025 [Best Colleges](#) edition used 17 key measures of academic quality for [National Universities](#) and 13 for [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#), [Regional Universities](#) and [Regional Colleges](#). Below is a more focused explanation about the indicators and their weights, highlighting changes made from the previous edition. You can find a wide-ranging explanation about how U.S. News produced the rankings from research to reporting in the article, "[How the College Rankings Were Calculated](#)."

Ranking Indicator Weights

The table below shows the weights in percentages assigned to each indicator. Schools without eligible data to be assessed on their new entrants' ACT/SAT scores for two consecutive years had this indicator's 5% weight reallocated to average graduation rates, making their scores on this ranking factor equal 27% of the formula.

The key difference between the weights for National Universities and those for all other rankings is that the National Universities methodology has four indicators pertaining to faculty research, which are aligned mission-wise with their Carnegie classifications as doctoral universities (explained in the article, "[Best Colleges Ranking Category Definitions](#)"). The other rankings apply this 4% weight across other faculty resource indicators. The previous rankings of National Universities had also introduced two additional ranking factors pertaining to the graduation rates of first-generation students; however, these were removed for the new edition based on clarification from the U.S. Department of Education about the limitations of the College Scorecard data in some cases.

National Universities 2025 Best Colleges Ranking Factor Weights

Indicator	2025 National Universities Weight for Schools With Usable SAT/ACT
Graduation rates	16%
First-year retention rates	5%
Graduation rate performance	10%
Pell graduation rates	5.5%
Pell graduation performance	5.5%
First-generation graduation rates	0%
First-generation graduation rate performance	0%
College grads earning more than a high school grad	5%
Borrower debt	5%
Peer assessment	20%
Financial resources per student	8%
Faculty salaries	6%
Full-time faculty	2%
Student-faculty ratio	3%
Standardized tests	5%
Citations per publication	1.25%
Field weighted citation impact	1.25%
Publications cited in top 5% of journals	1%
Publications cited in top 25% of journals	0.5%
TOTAL	100%



All Other Ranking Categories 2025 Best Colleges Ranking Factor Weights

Indicator	2025 Weight for Schools With Usable SAT/ACT
Graduation rates	16%
First-year retention rates	5%
Graduation rate performance	10%
Pell graduation rates	5.5%
Pell graduation performance	5.5%
College grads earning more than a high school grad	5%
Borrower debt	5%
Peer assessment	20%
Financial resources	8%
Faculty salaries	8%
Full-time faculty	3%
Student-faculty ratio	4%
Standardized tests	5%
Citations per publication	0%
Field weighted citations	0%
Citations in top 5% journals	0%
Citations in top 25% of journals	0%
TOTAL	100%



Definitions of Ranking Criteria

Borrower debt: This assesses each school's typical average accumulated federal loan debt among only borrowers who graduated. It was sourced from the [College Scorecard](#), a portal of higher education data administered by the Education Department.

The College Scorecard summed each graduate's federal loans over their college education, excluding PLUS loans, Perkins loans and any loans disbursed post-separation. For example, if an undergraduate receives a federal loan for \$2,000 for each of their eight semesters at one institution until graduating, their cumulative debt is recorded as \$16,000 for that institution.

U.S. News averaged the median values from the two most recent College Scorecard releases. For the second consecutive year, this reflected pooled cohort data from fiscal years 2019-2020 and 2020-2021. Averages for each school were calculated among all years for which data was available, which in some cases was only one year. The small minority of schools without data for at least one release, either because of low borrower cohorts or not accepting federal loans (e.g., military academies) were assigned high performing values under the assumption that their students were well supported. Because the figure is specific to only borrowers who graduated, both nongraduates and graduates who covered their expenses without borrowing did not help or hurt schools' rankings.

In a change for this edition, U.S. News calculated a school's percentile distribution of its debt value within its ranking before normalizing. In other words, all schools received a score between 1-99. This was done to minimize the effect of outlier values in the rankings on a statistic that has a lot of compression. Otherwise, a difference of only a couple thousand dollars in debt among the best and worst performing schools on this factor had a disproportionate impact on the rankings.

This indicator does not control for the proportion of graduates who borrowed. This is because while there are exceptions, in general whether a student needed to borrow to attend school is more often predicated on their household income than on the school's affordability.

College grads earning more than a high school grad: This assesses the proportion of a school's federal loan recipients who in 2019-2020 – five years since completing their undergraduate degrees – were earning more than the median salary of a 25-to-34-year-old whose highest level of education is high school. The previous rankings edition used this same cohort when it was four years since completing their undergraduate degrees. For this edition, the time period was changed to five years because this is the timespan that the Department of Education will update in future releases of the College Scorecard.

The College Scorecard produced this statistic by incorporating earnings data from the U.S. Department of the Treasury. Earnings are defined as the sum of wages and deferred compensation from all W-2 forms received for each individual, plus self-employment earnings from Schedule SE. The College Scorecard documented that the [median wage of workers](#) ages 25-34 that self-identify as high school graduates was

\$32,000 in 2021. The vast majority of jobs utilizing a college degree, even including those not chosen for being in high-paying fields, exceed this threshold.

The data only pertained to college and high school graduates employed in the workforce, meaning nongraduates, or graduates who four years later were continuing their education or simply not in the workforce, did not help or hurt any school.

U.S. News assigned a perfect score for the small minority of schools where at least 95% of graduates achieved the earnings threshold – up from 90% in the previous edition when the timespan after graduation was shorter. Remaining schools were assessed on how close they came to 95%. The cap was chosen to allow for a small proportion of graduates to elect low-paying jobs without negatively impacting a school's ranking.

The ranking factor's 5% weight in the overall ranking formula equals the weight for borrower debt because both earnings and debt are meaningful post-graduate outcomes.

Faculty research (National Universities only): To be grouped in the National Universities ranking, an institution must be categorized in the [Carnegie classification](#) as awarding doctorate-level degrees and conducting at least "moderate research." In alignment with these schools' missions, U.S. News again included four faculty research ranking factors based on bibliometric data in partnership with Elsevier. Although research is much less integral to undergraduate than graduate education – which is why these factors only contribute 4% in total to the ranking formula – undergraduates at universities can sometimes take advantage of departmental research opportunities, especially in upper-division classes. Even students not directly involved in research may still benefit by being taught by highly distinguished instructors. Also, the use of bibliometric data to measure faculty performance is well established in the field of academic research as a way to compare schools.

Only scaled factors were used so that the rankings measure the strength and impact of schools' professors on an individual level instead of the size of the university. However, universities with fewer than 5,000 total publications over five years were discounted on a sliding scale to reduce outliers based on small cohort sizes, and to require a minimum quantity of research to score well on the factors. The minority of universities with no data on record for an indicator were treated as zeros.

The four ranking factors below reflect a five-year window from 2019-2023 to account for year-to-year volatility. Each of the four metrics is extracted from SciVal based on Elsevier's Scopus® Data:

- **Citations per publication (1.25%):** This is total citations divided by total publications. It's the average number of citations a university's publications received.
- **Fields weighted citation impact (1.25%):** This is citation impact per paper, normalized for field, year of publication and publication type. This means a school receives more credit for its citations when in fields of study that are less widely cited overall.

- **The share of publications cited in the top 5% of the most cited journals (1%):** This is the share of an institution's publications published in the top 5% of the most cited journals by Elsevier's CiteScore.
- **The share of publications cited in the top 25% of the most cited journals (0.5%):** This is the share of an institution's publications published in the top 25% of the most cited journals by Elsevier's CiteScore.

The [Elsevier Research Metrics Guidebook](#) has detailed explanations of the four indicators used.

Each factor was calculated for the entire university. Elsevier compiled the number of publications – limited to peer-reviewed documents and books – that could be linked to each institution by name based on the institutional addresses of publications' authors.

Elsevier, a global leader in information and analytics, helps researchers and health care professionals advance science and improve health outcomes for the benefit of society. It does this by facilitating insights and critical decision-making for customers across the global research and health ecosystems. To learn more, visit its [website](#).

Faculty salaries: Research shows there is a link between teacher's pay and student achievement. This indicator averaged salaries – excluding nonsalary benefits – from all of a school's full-time instructional tenured and nontenured faculty who were professors, associate professors, assistant professors, instructors, lecturers and those having no rank. Altogether, higher average faculty salaries score better than lower average faculty salaries.

The reporting standards in U.S. News' survey aligned with definitions from the [American Association of University Professors \(AAUP\)](#). The 2023-2024 academic year data was used for this most recent edition.

U.S. News annualized all reported salaries so they were on the same nine-month scale by multiplying reported 12-month salaries by 0.818. The annualized cumulative salaries were then divided by total faculty to produce an average salary for each school. This amount was then adjusted by differences in cost of living using the publicly available December 2023 update to the [Regional Price Parities by State and Metro Area](#) indexes from the U.S. Department of Commerce's Bureau of Economic Analysis. The BEA's regional price indexes allow comparisons of buying power for a given year and cover all consumption goods and services, including housing rent. The adjustments were determined by each school's core-based statistical area (CBSA), or metro area, with schools outside a CBSA adjusted by their state's nonmetropolitan area average.

Schools that declined to report faculty salary data to U.S. News alternatively were assessed on fall 2022 data sourced from the Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System \(IPEDS\)](#) human resources survey. IPEDS is housed in the department's National Center for Education Statistics. Besides being a year older, the IPEDS definitions are less refined than AAUP definitions in capturing faculty most likely to be in contact with students. According to [the FAQ on the AAUP website](#), it collects typical salaries of faculty members to help institutions achieve correction or mitigation of the distortion in salary

structures, whereas the IPEDS human resources survey component seeks to collect institution-level data on salaries of full-time instructional staff.

Despite the different definitions, the salary amounts schools report to U.S. News typically bear resemblance to what they reported to IPEDS. During its July 2024 outreach to schools, U.S. News contacted several institutions whose reported faculty salary data differed the most significantly from IPEDS, including respondents who declined to report salary information on faculty ranks for which they had reported to IPEDS. Schools that did not respond with satisfactory confirmations or updates were scored using IPEDS data.

Financial resources: This represents a school's ability to have a strong environment for instruction and impact in academia. Financial resources are measured by comparing an institution's total expenditures on instruction, research, public service, academic support, student services and institutional support against its total academic year full-time equivalent student enrollment. This means only spending that can be associated with academics is included, while other spending is excluded. Higher average expenditures per student score better than lower expenditures in the ranking model.

Because the Best Colleges rankings are for undergraduates, U.S. News first discounts the public service and research amounts by multiplying each by the percentage of students attending the school who were full-time-equivalent undergraduates. This is done to account for schools with robust graduate programs likely having greater research and public service focuses that have more limited relevance to undergraduate experiences.

To calculate full-time equivalency, part-time undergraduate and graduate students are counted as one-third of full-time undergraduate and graduate students.

U.S. News used fiscal year 2022 expenditures data and 2021-2022 academic year enrollment data from the IPEDS fall enrollment survey. In previous editions, U.S. News compared expenditures to fall enrollment. A full academic year was used starting with this edition because expenditures reflect a full year; therefore the full-time and part-time enrollment should also reflect a full year.

Expenditures data was also sourced directly from the most recent [IPEDS finance survey](#). For a handful of cases, U.S. News accepted data directly from schools in cases when their campus was too new to have FY 2022 data in IPEDS or if they informed U.S. News they had submitted a correction to IPEDS that should be reflected in a future final release.

Once again, the spending per-student amounts were converted to percentile distributions before being normalized. This had the impact of assuming diminishing returns on increased spending, but the percentile distribution approach further smoothed dispersed outlier values.

First-year retention rates: This is the average proportion of the first-year classes entering from fall 2019 through fall 2022 who returned to school the following fall. A higher average first-year retention rate scores better than a lower average retention rate in the ranking model because students staying enrolled demonstrates a school's continued appeal.

U.S. News instructed survey respondents to adhere to IPEDS definitions for student retention and graduation data. The three historic years of retention rate data were consistently sourced from the IPEDS fall enrollment survey because IPEDS definitions match the Common Data Set (CDS) definitions in U.S. News' survey. Fall 2022 data was from the U.S. News statistical survey, fall 2021 data was from IPEDS' provisional release, and fall 2020 and 2019 data were sourced from IPEDS' final releases. This historic IPEDS data is publicly available from the Education Department, but is also readily available in [Academic Insights](#) – U.S. News' historical archive of rankings data.

There needed to be at least 20 students in the cohort for it to be incorporated into the nonweighted average. A school's average rate was calculated only among the four years from which there was usable data. Nonresponders to U.S. News' survey could therefore have been scored on as many as three years of data.

The fall 2021 retention rate data that schools reported to IPEDS was not available to the public during the time U.S. News conducted quality assurance for the rankings. However, U.S. News emailed schools whose reported values differed greatly from what was in IPEDS the three previous years.

Full-time faculty: This is the proportion of the fall 2023 instructional faculty that was full time. Although part-time staff too can be excellent instructors, full-time faculty are more likely than part-time faculty to be experienced professors who are distinguished in their fields as subject matter experts. Additionally, the faculty salaries ranking factor only is able to account for the earnings of full-time instructors; therefore, the more dependent a school is on part-time instructors, the less representative those salary figures are of all staff and the greater the need to counterbalance with this additional ranking factor.

We compared the count of full-time instructional faculty members with the count of full-time-equivalent faculty members (full-time faculty members plus one-third the count of part-time faculty members). A school scores higher with the greater its proportion of faculty members who are full time.

In alignment with the 2022-2023 [CDS](#) instructions, U.S. News does not include faculty in preclinical and clinical medicine; administrative officers with titles such as dean of students, librarian, registrar or coach, even though they may devote part of their time to classroom instruction and may have faculty status; undergraduate or graduate students who are teaching assistants or teaching fellows; faculty members on leave without pay; or replacement faculty for faculty members on sabbatical leave.

Schools that declined to report faculty data to U.S. News were assessed on fall 2022 data reported to the IPEDS human resources survey. Besides being a year older, schools reporting to IPEDS are instructed to report on a broader group of faculty, including those in roles that typically have less interaction with undergraduates, such as part-time staff working in university hospitals.

Graduation rates: This is the percentage of entering full-time first-year bachelor's or equivalent degree-seeking students who completed a bachelor's or equivalent degree within a six-year period, averaged over the classes entering from fall 2014 through fall 2017. A higher average graduation rate scores better than a lower graduation rate in the ranking because completion is integral for students to get the most value in their careers from their education.

Six years was chosen because this is 150% of the normal time needed for a student to earn a four-year degree, meaning students could take limited time away from college without it negatively affecting their schools' performances. Full-time, first-year students were assessed because this data provides the most standardized comparisons, and because the Best Colleges rankings only included institutions that administered programs for traditional four-year program students. True bachelor's degree graduation rates instead of overall graduation rates (that may include certificates and associate degrees conferred to bachelor's-seeking students) were also assessed for fair comparisons.

Schools reported directly to U.S. News the fall 2017 entering class graduation rates data. Fall 2014 through fall 2016 data was consistently sourced from IPEDS because U.S. News' instructions aligned with those of the Department of Education. Fall 2016 used the IPEDS provisional release of its completions survey, while fall 2015 and fall 2014 used the final release. As is the case with retention rates, this historic IPEDS data is newly available in [Academic Insights](#) – U.S. News' historical archive of rankings data.

At least 20 students in the cohort were required for it to be incorporated into the nonweighted average. A school's average rate was calculated only among the four years from which there was usable data. Nonresponders to U.S. News' survey could therefore have been scored on as many as three years of data.

U.S. News instructed survey respondents to adhere to IPEDS definitions for graduation rate data. During the time U.S. News conducted quality assurance on data schools reported directly to U.S. News, the six-year bachelor's degree graduation rates of fall 2017 new entrants was displayed in the National Center for Education Statistics' College Navigator tool. U.S. News crosschecked the reported values against College Navigator and emailed all schools with discrepancies. In many cases, schools updated their values, curing not only the graduation rate data but the underlying statistics used in the two Pell graduation rate ranking factors that used data not yet publicly available to crosscheck.

Graduation rate performance: This is a four-year rolling average comparing each college's six-year graduation rates with what U.S. News predicted for their fall 2014 through fall 2017 entering classes.

If the actual graduation rate is higher than the predicted rate, the college is enhancing achievement or is overperforming. If its actual graduation rate is lower than the predicted rate, it's underperforming. For all cohorts, U.S. News divided the actual rate by the predicted rate and then averaged each quotient. The higher the average of ratios, the better the score. For a white paper on how this indicator was calculated, click [here](#). Here is a shorter summary:

This indicator of added value shows the effect of the college's programs and policies on the six-year graduation rate of students by comparing it with a predicted graduation rate calculated using a multivariate regression. In effect, the measure assessed how well schools graduate students after controlling for spending per student, the proportion of undergraduates receiving Pell Grants, standardized test scores and high school class standing of entering classes. The proportion of undergraduates who are first-generation college students, sourced from College Scorecard, was removed from the formulas based on clarification from the Education Department about the limitations of the College Scorecard data in some cases. But the proportion of science, technology, engineering and math, or STEM, degrees out of the total degrees granted was a variable used to calculate the predicted graduation rate for each school in the National Universities ranking category only.

To determine whether an awarded degree was considered STEM, U.S. News used the U.S. Department of Homeland Security's STEM Designated Degree Program list. The list includes a diverse array of degrees in general STEM areas such as biology and engineering, as well as specific STEM degree tracks in nontraditional STEM fields, such as business statistics and digital communication and media.

High school class standing data is sourced from old U.S. News surveys because it is not available elsewhere. SAT/ACT scores were primarily sourced from old U.S. News surveys because the data was specific to bachelor's students instead of reflecting all undergraduates. The remaining data was sourced from IPEDS.

A school without data on at least one of the variables had its predicted value computed via a simulation that made use of all its available data.

For the three older years, U.S. News re-used its graduation rate performance scores calculated from the previous editions.

Peer assessment: This is a measure of how a school is regarded by top administrators at other institutions and accounts for qualitative attributes of schools that may not be fully captured by the other ranking factors. A school's peer assessment score is calculated from the weighted, two-year rolling average of ratings on academic quality it received by presidents, provosts and deans of admissions – or officials in equivalent positions – at institutions submitting a peer assessment survey administered by U.S. News.

Each survey respondent was asked to rate the overall academic quality of peer schools' undergraduate academic programs on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). For example, schools in the National Universities ranking could only rate any of the other schools in the National Universities ranking. Respondents who did not know enough about a school to evaluate it fairly were asked to mark "don't know" or leave it blank, neither of which counted for or against a school's score.

U.S. News collected the most recent data by administering peer assessment surveys to schools in spring and summer 2024. Of the 4,665 academics who were sent questionnaires, 30.7% responded. The peer assessment response rate in 2024 for National Universities was 41% and for National Liberal Arts Colleges was 47%.

Whether a school submitted a peer assessment survey or statistical survey had no impact on the average peer score it received from other schools. However, schools that did not respond to U.S. News' statistical survey who submitted peer surveys had their ratings of other schools excluded from the computations.

Pell graduation rates: This relates to six-year graduation rates of students who received Pell Grants. Pell Grants are a need-based award issued by the Education Department – typically to students from households earning less than \$50,000 a year, although most Pell Grant money goes to students with a total family income below \$20,000 a year. There are two ranking factors assessing the graduation rates of Pell students – both of which were calculated as four-year averages of the final transformed values U.S. News calculated for each cohort. Values were converted to percentile distributions before normalization to smooth the effects of outlier values on normalized scores. Completions data for Pell recipients among the fall 2017 entering cohort of full-time, first-year, bachelor's degree-seeking students was reported directly by schools to U.S. News, while the three earlier cohorts were sourced from IPEDS provisional data for fall

2016 and final data for fall 2014 and 2015. Because the graduation rates of first-generation students was removed from the National Universities formula, both ranking factors increased in weight to 5.5% each in the National Universities category, matching the weights used in the other rankings categories.

- **Pell Grant graduation rates:** To calculate this, U.S. News started with an entering class of full-time, first-year, bachelor's degree-seeking students who were awarded Pell Grants, and calculated a graduation rate based on the count among that cohort who completed their degree program within six years. Because achieving results from a broader base is more challenging, this graduation rate was summed with the proportion of the entering class awarded Pell Grants, capped at 0.5.
- **Pell Grant graduation rate performance:** This assesses success at achieving equitable outcomes for students from underserved backgrounds. To start, schools' six-year graduation rates of Pell Grant students were divided by the six-year graduation rates of all other students from the full-time, first-year, bachelor's degree-seeking entering class. For most schools, this produced a quotient less than one, but the minority of schools whose Pell graduation rates are equal to or greater than non-Pell graduation rates all began with the highest initial score of 1. Additional credit was summed based on the proportion of the entering class that received Pell Grants. Schools whose entering cohorts were at least 50% Pell Grant students had their scores augmented by 0.5; schools below 50% Pell Grant students had their scores augmented by the proportion that received Pell Grants.

Schools were instructed to adhere to IPEDS definitions in reporting these graduation rates for bachelor's degree-seeking students who completed with a bachelor's degree. Although fall 2017 data was publicly available in IPEDS during the time of U.S. News' quality assurance, data schools reported was compared against data reported the three previous years to determine which data required outreach. Note that because Pell awarded students are a subset of all students, there is greater volatility with the graduation rates of Pell students than with all students.

Standardized test scores: Median test scores on both the SAT math and evidence-based reading and writing portions, and the composite ACT of all enrolled first-time, first-year students entering in fall 2023 are combined for the ranking model. These tests are used in the rankings because they measure a school's ability to attract students who can handle rigorous coursework. A higher median entering class test score on the SAT math and evidence-based reading and writing portions and the composite ACT does better than a lower median SAT and ACT test score in the ranking model. When only the 25th and 75th percentile scores were available, the midpoint between the two values was used.

Before being used as a ranking factor, the reported scores from both SAT tests and the ACT composite test were each converted to their national percentile distributions. To most accurately represent the entire entering class, U.S. News used a calculation based on the percentage of the fall entering class that submitted each test. For example, if twice as many applicants to a school submitted ACT scores versus SAT scores, the ACT scores would have twice as much effect on that school's ranking.

A majority of schools are currently test optional or test blind, the latter of which means not using test scores at all in admissions decisions. For fair comparisons and to take into account the changing nature of admissions, the following methodology was used for the third consecutive year in the rankings:

By default, we assessed schools on their fall 2023 SAT/ACT scores if they were reported on at least half of their new entrants.

- For schools not meeting the first condition, they were assessed on their fall 2022 SAT/ACT scores (scaled to fall 2022 percentile distributions) if they were reported on at least half of their fall 2022 new entrants.
- For schools reporting SAT/ACT scores on less than 50% of both their fall 2023 and fall 2022 entering classes – including test-blind schools – they were not assessed at all on standardized tests. Instead, for those schools we increased the weights of graduation rates an additional five percentage points, from 16% to 21%. This substitute was chosen because it was the statistic from the rankings formula that correlated closest to standardized tests.

Out of fairness to schools eligible to be scored on exams, their normalized values were computed assuming schools not scored on tests would typically have had reported low scores. This ensured that schools scored on their SAT/ACT were not disadvantaged by being compared against mean and standard deviation test scores only among a subset of schools whose new entrants' test scores were likely higher than average.

Schools not assessed on SAT/ACT scores were not consistently helped or hurt by their test requirement policies because of the weight reallocation. However, schools performing well on the SAT/ACT indicator tend to have higher normalized scores than they had on average graduation rates because of the distribution of data in which schools not eligible to be scored on SAT/ACT had imputed low test scores for the purpose of calculating z-scores. Even so, 12 of the top 50 ranked National Universities were not assessed on standardized tests scores despite the greater use of testing among highly selective institutions.

At test-optional schools, prospective students often elected to submit SAT/ACT scores based on whether they believed these scores were strong enough to improve their applications. Based on U.S. News' research, those admitted to the most highly selective institutions without submitting scores would have otherwise reported scores whose national percentile distributions were a little worse than the rest of the student body, with the gap widening for less selective institutions. Consequently, U.S. News made a change for this edition out of fairness in which schools received bonus credit on the ranking factor as a function of their percent submits and national percentile distributions of reported scores. This meant a school reporting very high scores reflecting barely half of new entrants received virtually no bonus, while a school with nationally average scores reported on their entire entering student body received a larger bonus. These bonuses are generally incremental, with half of the qualifying National Universities receiving a bonus for the national percentile distributions of approximately two percentage points or less. For example, a university that reported a median ACT of 25 and median SAT of 1210 on all of its new entrants scored two percentage points higher on its final score than a university that reported virtually identical scores (25 and 1230) on 58% of its new entrants.

This is the second consecutive year median scores were used in the formulas, meaning schools were assessed on median scores regardless of whether fall 2023 or fall 2022 data was used in the computations.

The one ranking factor in which U.S. News deviated from CDS definition standards was with SAT/ACT scores. Once again, U.S. News instructed schools to report more closely following the IPEDS definition of only including new entrants who submitted scores used toward admissions decisions. This change was to

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ensure that schools following CDS definitions were not disadvantaged for reporting on a broader pool of applicants who had taken standardized tests but did not want them considered.

A distinction between the U.S. News definition and IPEDS, however, was that U.S. News instructed schools to report only on bachelor's-degree seeking new entrants. This means for some schools the values match between U.S. News and IPEDS, whereas schools with many non-bachelor's seeking undergraduates had larger discrepancies – especially on the percent submitting scores because of the infrequency of associate-degree seeking undergraduates submitting them in their applications.

Even so, schools that declined to report fall 2023 SAT/ACT data to U.S. News were assessed on any data schools reported to IPEDS for fall 2022, if the data was reported on at least half of new entrants.

Student-faculty ratio: This is the ratio of full-time-equivalent students to full-time-equivalent faculty members during fall 2023, aligned with 2023-2024 CDS instructions for reporting faculty. A lower student-faculty ratio (fewer students per each faculty member) scores better than a higher ratio in the ranking.

This excludes faculty and students of law, medical, business and other stand-alone graduate or professional programs in which faculty members teach virtually only graduate-level students. Faculty numbers also exclude graduate or undergraduate students who are teaching assistants.

For the computation, a part-time instructional faculty member was equated to one-third of a full-time instructional faculty member.

Schools that declined to report this data to U.S. News were assessed on fall 2022 data schools reported to the IPEDS human resources survey. Besides the data being a year older, schools reporting to IPEDS are instructed to report on a broader group of faculty than under the CDS instructions used in the U.S. News survey, such as those in roles that typically have less interaction with undergraduates, like part-time staff working in university hospitals.

How U.S. News Calculated the 2025 Best Colleges Rankings

Find out what is new with how we crunched the numbers.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

The Mission

There are plenty of reasons to attend a particular college or university. But students' top ones involve academic reputation, cost of attendance and return on investment, according to several different surveys, such as [Why Higher Ed?](#) by Strada and Gallup and [Factors That Influence Student College Choice](#) by the U.S. Department of Education.

The 40th annual edition of Best Colleges took those priorities into account. Based on statistics, the top-ranked schools provided ample classroom resources for students and faculty; conferred bachelor's degrees at high rates; and produced graduates who entered the workforce with manageable debt and worthwhile starting salaries.

Rankings aside, student preferences matter too – including which majors are offered, the clubs and activities available, and the ease of fitting in with life on campus. This is why U.S. News pairs its rankings with detailed profiles and user reviews for each school, plus a [search](#) feature to help discover them. There are also customized rankings and lists like the [Best Value Schools](#) rankings and listings of schools with greatest [campus diversity](#).

Altogether, the rankings are a guide for discovering [the best fit schools](#) predicated on academics and personal considerations. This aligns with U.S. News' mission of helping consumers, business leaders and policy officials make important decisions in their lives through independent reporting, data and rankings, journalism, and advice. For more about this, read [Why U.S. News Ranks the Best Colleges and Universities](#).

Eligibility

The Best Colleges guide is designed to connect soon-to-be and recent high school graduates with traditional four-year baccalaureate programs in the U. S. That is reflected in the ranking factors and the following eligibility criteria for the overall rankings:

- Be located in the U. S.
- Have regional accreditation
- Be designated as a bachelor's degree-granting institution in [Carnegie's Basic Classification](#) but not designated as a "highly specialized" school
- Enroll at least 100 undergraduate students

- Have financial expenditure figures available in the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) Data Center
- Have a six-year bachelor's degree graduation rate of full-time, first-year bachelor's degree-seeking students
- Actively accepting new applicants for first-year, first-time students

Schools that were ineligible because they were too highly specialized or did not have a baccalaureate degree graduation rate still received a profile on usnews.com; and while they displayed as unranked for the overall rankings, they may still have been eligible for discipline-specific rankings and other evaluative lists. In contrast, ineligible institutions that lacked accreditation, were closing, or were mostly distance education entities do not have Best Colleges profiles on usnews.com. Accredited institutions with distance education baccalaureate programs – including degree completion programs – could be ranked and have profiles in the separate rankings for the [Best Online Bachelor's Programs](#).

As always, schools' eligibility to be ranked was not contingent on their participation in U.S. News' surveys. But the vast majority of schools U.S. News surveyed did report data to U.S. News, including 99 of the top 100 ranked National Universities and 96 of the top 100 National Liberal Arts Colleges.

How Ranks Are Determined

U.S. News ranked nearly 1,500 U.S. four-year bachelor's degree-granting institutions, grouped within 10 distinct overall rankings where colleges and universities were compared with schools that shared their academic mission:

- **National Universities** offer a range of undergraduate majors, plus master's and doctoral programs, and emphasize faculty research or award professional practice doctorates.
- **National Liberal Arts Colleges** focus almost exclusively on undergraduate education and award at least 50% of their degrees in the arts and sciences.
- **Regional Universities** offer a broad scope of undergraduate degrees and some master's degree programs but few, if any, doctoral programs. We ranked them in four geographical regions: North, South, Midwest and West.
- **Regional Colleges** focus on undergraduate education but grant fewer than 50% of their degrees in liberal arts disciplines. Some regional colleges award two-year associate degrees as well as bachelor's degrees. We ranked them in four geographical regions: North, South, Midwest and West.

The above were mapped for the third consecutive year with the Carnegie Classification of Institutions of Higher Education's 2021 update to its [Basic Classification](#) system (see details [here](#)).

Each ranking has ranking factors – outlined below – for which each eligible school was scored on its underlying data. These scores were standardized (z-scored) so they were compared with the means and

standard deviations among all other ranked schools. In other words, the distance between two schools on any ranking factor is not determined by how their data compared head-to-head so much as how their data compared with every ranked school.

Next, the standardized values were weighted and totaled to determine the overall score from which the rankings were derived. The overall scores were rescaled so that the top performer(s) in each ranking displays an overall score of 100. Others' overall scores are on a 0-99 scale reflecting the distance from their ranking's top-performing school(s). Those placing outside the top 90% are still ranked but display their ranking's bottom decile range (e.g., No. 118-130) instead of their individual ranks (e.g., No. 126).

The Ranking Factors

Below is an outline of the 17 ranking factors. Although the 2025 edition's ranking formula is mostly intact from the previous year's, there were some changes. As always, changes in methodology together with changes in individual schools' data can contribute to significant changes to schools' rankings.

For a deeper dive into how the ranking factors were calculated, including the new ones, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)." Also see the [Morse Code: Inside the College Rankings](#) blog for insights behind these changes.

National Universities 2025 Best Colleges Overall Ranking Criteria and Weights

Indicator	2025 National Universities Weight for Schools With Usable SAT/ACT	2025 National Universities Weight for Schools Without Usable SAT/ACT	2024 Weight
Graduation rates	16%	21%	16%
First-year retention rates	5%	5%	5%
Graduation rate performance	10%	10%	10%
Pell graduation rates	5.5%	5.5%	3%
Pell graduation performance	5.5%	5.5%	3%
First-generation graduation rates	0%	0%	2.5%
First-generation graduation rate performance	0%	0%	2.5%
College grads earning more than a high school grad	5%	5%	5%
Borrower debt	5%	5%	5%
Peer assessment	20%	20%	20%
Financial resources per student	8%	8%	8%
Faculty salaries	6%	6%	6%
Full-time faculty	2%	2%	2%
Student-faculty ratio	3%	3%	3%
Standardized tests	5%	0%	5%
Citations per publication	1.25%	1.25%	1.25%
Field weighted citation impact	1.25%	1.25%	1.25%
Publications cited in top 5% of journals	1%	1%	1%
Publications cited in top 25% of journals	0.5%	0.5%	0.5%
TOTAL	100%	100%	100%

All Other Ranking Categories Overall 2025 Best Colleges Ranking Criteria and Weights

Indicator	2025 Weight for Schools With Usable SAT/ACT	2025 Weight for Schools Without Usable SAT/ACT	2024 Weight
Graduation rates	16%	21%	16%
First-year retention rates	5%	5%	5%
Graduation rate performance	10%	10%	10%
Pell graduation rates	5.5%	5.5%	5.5%
Pell graduation performance	5.5%	5.5%	5.5%
College grads earning more than a high school grad	5%	5%	5%
Borrower debt	5%	5%	5%
Peer assessment	20%	20%	20%
Financial resources	8%	8%	8%
Faculty salaries	8%	8%	8%
Full-time faculty	3%	3%	3%
Student-faculty ratio	4%	4%	4%
Standardized tests	5%	0%	5%
Citations per publication	0%	0%	0%
Field weighted citations	0%	0%	0%
Citations in top 5% journals	0%	0%	0%
Citations in top 25% of journals	0%	0%	0%
TOTAL	100%	100%	100%

Embargoed – Subject to Change

Outcomes

More than half of a school's rank now comprises varying outcome measures related to schools' success at enrolling, retaining and graduating students from different backgrounds with manageable debt and postgraduation success.

Graduation rates (16%): This is a four-year rolling average of the proportion of each bachelor's degree-seeking entering class (fall 2014 through fall 2017) that earned a bachelor's degree in six years or less.

First-year retention rates (5%): This is a four-year rolling average of the proportions of first-year entering students (fall 2019 through fall 2022) who returned the following fall.

Graduation rate performance (10%): This is a four-year rolling average comparing each college's six-year graduation rates with what we predicted for their fall 2014 through fall 2017 entering classes, based on each school's characteristics. The more a school's actual graduation rate exceeded its predicted graduation rate, the more it exceeded expectations – and scored higher on this indicator.

Social mobility: This assesses how well schools graduated economically disadvantaged students. The ranking factors, which feed standalone [Top Performers on Social Mobility](#) rankings, were computed by aggregating two distinct ranking factors assessing graduation rates of students who were awarded Pell Grants. Last edition, the graduation rates of first-generation students were also incorporated, but they were dropped this year based on clarification about the limitations of the College Scorecard data in some cases.

- **Pell graduation rates (5.5%):** This is a four-year rolling average that incorporates six-year bachelor's degree-seeking graduation rates of Pell Grant students from the fall 2014 through fall 2017 entering classes, adjusted to give much more credit to schools with larger Pell student proportions.
- **Pell graduation performance (5.5%):** This compares each school's six-year bachelor's degree-seeking graduation rate among Pell Grant recipients with its six-year graduation rates among non-Pell recipients, then adjusts to give significantly more credit to schools who enrolled larger Pell student proportions. The higher a school's Pell graduation rate relative to its non-Pell graduation rate up to the rates being equal, the better it scores. This, too, is computed as a four-year rolling average from the fall 2014 through fall 2017 entering classes.

Borrower debt (5%): This assesses each school's typical average accumulated federal loan debt among borrowers only. The data was sourced from College Scorecard and again averaged 2019-2020 and 2020-2021 data because data on 2021-2022 graduates had not been released at the time the 2025 Best Colleges rankings were finalized.

College grads earning more than a high school graduate (5%): This assesses the proportion of a school's federal loan recipients who graduated in the 2014-2015 or the 2015-2016 academic years and five years later – in 2020 or 2021 – were earning more than a typical high school graduate salary, as determined by

and reported in the College Scorecard. Schools were assigned a perfect score if at least 95% of graduates achieved this threshold, and the remaining schools were assessed by how close they were to 95%. This was the same graduating cohort as used in the previous year's rankings but this time their earnings five years after graduation were assessed instead of four years after graduation, and therefore 95% instead 90% was assigned as the marker for a perfect score.

For more information, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)."

Peer assessment (20%): Academic reputation matters because it factors things that cannot easily be captured elsewhere. For example, an institution known for having innovative approaches to teaching may perform especially well on this indicator, whereas a school struggling to keep its accreditation will likely perform poorly.

Each year, top academics – presidents, provosts and deans of admissions – rate the academic quality of peer institutions with which they are familiar on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). U.S. News takes a two-year weighted average of the ratings. Those who don't know enough about a school to evaluate it fairly are asked to mark "don't know."

U.S. News collected the most recent data by administering peer assessment surveys to schools in spring and summer 2024. Of the 4,665 academics who were sent questionnaires on the overall rankings in 2024, 30.7% responded compared with 30.8% in 2023. In 2024, the peer assessment response rate for the National Universities category was 41% and the National Liberal Arts category was 47%.

Whether a school submitted a peer assessment survey or statistical survey had no impact on the average peer score it received from other schools. However, schools that did not respond to U.S. News' statistical survey who submitted peer surveys had their ratings of other schools excluded from the computations.

Schools interested in a breakdown of their peer assessment ratings by respondent type and region can access this information, along with 29 million other data points, with a subscription to U.S. News' [Academic Insights](#). This web-based platform facilitates a deep dive for studying and benchmarking the rankings and is designed for colleges and universities only.

Faculty resources: Research shows the greater access students have to quality instructors, the more engaged they will be in class and the more they will learn and be satisfied with their instructors. U.S. News uses three factors from the 2023-2024 academic year to assess a school's commitment to instruction. Their weights are each lower for the National Universities category than in other rankings to include the faculty research ranking factors.

- **Faculty salaries (6% in National Universities, 8% in other rankings):** This assesses the average salaries for full-time instructional faculty using definitions from the American Association of University Professors. Salary data was adjusted for regional differences in the cost of living using the U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis regional price parities indexes, published in December 2023.
- **Student-faculty ratio (3% in National Universities, 4% in other rankings):** This is the ratio of undergraduate students to instructional faculty.

- **Full-time faculty (2% in National Universities, 3% in all other rankings):** This compares the counts of full-time faculty to part-time faculty who are teaching courses, with a higher proportion of faculty teaching full-time receiving credit.

Financial resources (8%): Generous per-student academic spending indicates a college can offer a variety of programs and services. U.S. News measures financial resources by using the average spending per student on instruction, research, student services and related educational expenditures in the 2022 fiscal year; sourced directly from the IPEDS finance survey. Expenditures were compared with 2021-2022 academic year full-time equivalent total enrollment to produce a per-student figure. Enrollment data was sourced from the IPEDS fall enrollment survey. Spending on sports, dorms and hospitals doesn't count; U.S. News only considers the part of a school's budget that goes toward educating students. In previous years, the comparison had been to fall enrollment instead of the full year enrollment. For more information, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors.](#)"

Standardized tests (5%): U.S. News factors median test scores for all enrollees who submitted scores used in the admission process for the mathematics and evidence-based reading and writing portions of the SAT and the composite ACT. Both SATs and ACTs were converted to their 0-100 test-taker percentile distributions and weighted based on the proportions of new entrants submitting each exam. For example, if a school had two-thirds of its test-takers submitting ACT scores and one-third submitting SAT scores, its ACT scores would weigh twice as heavily as its SAT scores toward this ranking factor.

For the third year, the following two-year approach to the methodology was in effect:

- By default, we assessed schools on their fall 2023 SAT/ACT scores if they were reported on at least half their new entrants.
- For schools not meeting the first condition, we assessed them on their fall 2022 SAT/ACT scores (scaled to fall 2022 percentile distributions) only if they were reported on at least half their fall 2022 new entrants.
- For schools reporting SAT/ACT on less than 50% of both their fall 2023 and fall 2022 entering classes – including test-blind schools – we did not assess them on standardized tests at all. Instead, for those schools we increased the weight of graduation rates an additional five percentage points, from 16% to 21%. This substitute was chosen because it was the statistic from the rankings formula that correlated closest to standardized tests.

A change from previous editions was that schools with eligible SAT/ACT scores received slightly more credit when based on a higher proportion of students who submitted. For more information, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors.](#)"

Faculty research (National Universities only): To be grouped in the National Universities ranking, an institution must be classified in the Carnegie Classifications as awarding doctorate-level degrees and conducting at least "moderate research." In alignment with these schools' missions, U.S. News for the second year in row is using four faculty research ranking factors based on bibliometric data in partnership with Elsevier. They each reflect a five-year window from 2019 to 2023 as well as the strength and impact of the faculty instead of the scale of the university.

- **Citations per publication (1.25%):** This is total citations divided by total publications. It's the average number of citations a university's publications received.
- **Fields weighted citation impact (1.25%):** This is citation impact per paper, normalized for field, year of publication and publication type. This means a school receives more credit for its citations when in fields of study that are less widely cited overall.
- **The share of publications cited in the top 5% of the most cited journals (1%):** This is the share of an institution's publications published in the top 5% of the most cited journals by Elsevier's CiteScore.
- **The share of publications cited in the top 25% of the most cited journals (0.5%):** This is the share of an institution's publications published in the top 25% of the most cited journals by Elsevier's CiteScore.

Universities with fewer than 5,000 total publications over five years were discounted on a sliding scale to reduce outliers based on small cohort sizes, and to require a minimum quantity of research to score well on the factor. Each indicator is calculated at the school level.

Elsevier, a global leader in information and analytics, helps researchers and health care professionals advance science and improve health outcomes for the benefit of society. It does this by facilitating insights and critical decision-making for customers across the global research and health ecosystems. To learn more, visit its [website](#). For more information on the bibliometric factors, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)."

Defunct Rankings Factors

Acceptance rates, yield and alumni giving are among several factors no longer part of the ranking formulas. Data for them continues to be updated for informational purposes on school profiles on usnews.com and in Academic Insights.

Data Sources

The underlying data used to compute the rankings was collected from third-party sources, and often reported directly by schools to U.S. News in alignment with what they recently reported to the government and/or following Common Data Set (CDS) initiative guidance.

U.S. News only used ranking factors directly from third-party sources or from its own data collection using industry standard definitions. For missing U.S. News statistical survey data, one year or older data from the U.S. Department of Education's National Center for Education Statistics was substituted, using its IPEDS Data Center tool.

Most data from IPEDS used its latest provisional data release. According to the IPEDS [methodology](#), the data undergoes an initial review and validation process, which includes following up with institutions. However, the provisional data has not been extensively reviewed or edited. In contrast, earlier data U.S.

News applies to the rankings – such as data used in multi-year averages – is from the IPEDS final data, from which institutions may revise their data should they detect an error.

Data for the rankings not collected in U.S. News' surveys or downloaded from IPEDS was either supplied directly to U.S. News by Elsevier or downloaded from College Scorecard. This online tool run by the U.S. Department of Education houses a repository of publicly downloadable federal data on higher education institutions, including statistics on the outcomes of federal student loan recipients from the National Student Loan Data System.

Schools' eligibility to be ranked was not contingent on their participation in U.S. News' surveys. Schools that did not respond to U.S. News' statistical survey and were eligible to be ranked had their ranking based directly on the third-party sources described above.

For every ranking factor that averaged statistics across multiple years' reporting, U.S. News only incorporated data available. For example, if only three years of graduation rate data for a school were available, U.S. News calculated its average graduation rate based on three years instead of the default amount of four years.

U.S. News' Data Collection and Quality Assurance

This year, 78.1% (a slight decline compared to 79.9% last year) of the nearly 1,500 ranked institutions in the overall ranking returned their statistical information in the spring and summer of 2024. In total, U.S. News has collected data on more than 1,800 institutions, which all appear on usnews.com.

For ease of comprehension, the data on the U.S. News website displays a statistic used in the rankings computations – typically from the most recent cohort year – and not the final transformed values produced for the rankings.

Below is a summary of how U.S. News collects and reviews data. Please read [How U.S. News Collects Best Colleges Rankings Data](#) for more details.

Many of the reporting instructions in U.S. News' surveys were from the 2023-2024 [Common Data Set](#) – a collaborative effort between publishers and higher education, of which U.S. News is a participant. The CDS questions on faculty often align with those from the American Association of University Professors, which collect more refined, relevant faculty data than what is available from other sources.

While U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data, we take steps to review its accuracy.

For quality assurance, data schools reported to U.S. News was algorithmically compared with their previous year's submissions to detect possible inaccuracies. Respondents were required to review, possibly revise and verify any flagged data before they could submit their surveys, as well as explain in writing any large changes. They were also instructed to have a top academic official sign off on the accuracy of the data. Schools that declined this last step could still be ranked, but display a footnote on their profile on usnews.com.

U.S. News assessed the data submitted on a factor-by-factor level and contacted select schools to confirm or revise data. This process compared schools' data with third-party data when available, as well as with submissions from other ranked schools, the school's other statistics and previous submissions. Schools that did not respond or were unable to confirm their data's accuracy may have had the data in question unpublished and not used in the calculations. Altogether, U.S. News made updates to more than 100 indicator values pertaining to several dozens of schools following data collection.

Editorial Independence

U.S. News' mission in creating the Best Colleges rankings is to serve the best interests of students and their families, and to do so, we, like other reputable journalists, are editorially independent of our employer's business operations. A school's license of a "Best Colleges" badge or its purchase of advertising or other products from U.S. News does not affect whether that school is ranked, either currently or in the future, and, if ranked, whether it is ranked higher or lower. Below are a few products offered by U.S. News that are administered by staff not involved in calculating the rankings.

About [College Compass](#)

Subscribers can access the full data on usnews.com through a College Compass account. Prospective students can use the [My Fit](#) search tool within College Compass to enter up to 23 different criteria and U.S. News will rank the schools based on their preferences. They can save the schools and research them individually.

About the [2025 Best Colleges Guidebook](#)

This print publication has the full overall rankings and corresponding statistics used in the computations in an easy-to-skim format. Also included are several other rankings and lists, and comprehensive advice for high school students and their families who are researching college choices. The guidebook is available for preorder and will be published in November.

About [Student Connect](#)

Schools can also learn about Student Connect, U.S. News' higher education branding and recruitment marketing solution designed to connect them with prospective students. This helps make the decision easier for future students by adding branding to schools' profiles on usnews.com, and provides schools the opportunity to connect with students directly.

About [Academic Insights](#)

This web-based platform facilitates a deep dive for studying and benchmarking the rankings and is designed for researchers at colleges and universities only.

More to Come ...

Check out usnews.com throughout the year, as we may get new information and add to the Best Colleges rankings. And as you mine these rankings tables for insights – where you might win some merit aid, for

example, or where you will be apt to get the most attention from professors – keep in mind that they provide a [launching pad](#), not an easy answer.

Embargoed – Subject to Change

Best Colleges Ranking Category Definitions

Understand how U.S. News differentiates colleges and universities for the rankings.

By Robert Morse, Eric Brooks, and Sam Wellington

U.S. News & World Report ranks universities and colleges in three steps.

First, U.S. News sorts schools into the appropriate categories for comparisons. Second, we gather data for the 2025 Best Colleges ranking indicators used to measure academic quality from each school and tabulate them. Finally, we rank colleges in their categories by their total weighted score.

To determine the categories used for the 2025 edition of the [Best Colleges](#) rankings, U.S. News followed the Carnegie Classification of Institutions of Higher Education's [Basic Classification](#) system.

In February 2022, Carnegie released its final updates, called the 2021 update, to the categories, including the Basic system. U.S. News followed the Carnegie 2021 update for the third consecutive year in its Best Colleges rankings.

The Carnegie classification, which higher education researchers use extensively, has been the basis of the Best Colleges ranking category system since the publication of the first rankings in 1983. The U.S. Department of Education and many higher education associations use the Carnegie system to organize or label their data. In some cases, the Carnegie classification is used to determine colleges' eligibility for grant money. In short, the Carnegie categories are the accepted standard in U.S. higher education.

U.S. News collapses 10 of the Carnegie categories from the Basic Classification into four main groupings: [National Universities](#), [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#), [Regional Universities](#) and [Regional Colleges](#).

Schools in the Regional Universities and Regional Colleges categories are placed into one of four geographic regions: North, South, Midwest and West.

The following are descriptions of the categories U.S. News uses in the Best Colleges rankings.

National Universities: There are 436 National Universities in the country (225 public, 207 private and four for-profit). These universities offer a full range of undergraduate majors as well as master's and doctoral degrees, and many strongly emphasize research. The Carnegie classification defines them as Doctoral Universities: Very high research activity, Doctoral Universities: High research activity, and Doctoral/Professional Universities, which grant professional practice doctoral degrees. These professional degrees include such degrees as the M.D., J.D., Pharm.D. and D.Div.

National Liberal Arts Colleges: The 211 National Liberal Arts Colleges (19 public, 192 private and zero for-profit) emphasize undergraduate education and award at least 50% of their degrees in the liberal arts. The Carnegie classification defines them as Baccalaureate Colleges: Arts and Sciences Focus.

Regional Universities: The 590 total Regional Universities (237 public, 338 private and 15 for-profit) are ranked within four geographic areas: North, South, Midwest and West. Like the National Universities, Regional Universities – defined by the Carnegie classification as Master's Colleges and Universities: Larger programs, Master's Colleges and Universities: Medium programs, and Master's Colleges and Universities: Small programs – provide a range of undergraduate programs and some master's-level programs. They offer few, if any, doctoral programs.

Regional Colleges: There are a total of 397 Regional Colleges (197 public, 185 private and 15 for-profit) ranked within four regions: North, South, Midwest and West. These institutions focus primarily on undergraduate education, like the National Liberal Arts Colleges, but grant fewer than 50% of their degrees in liberal arts disciplines. Some of these schools have small bachelor's degree programs.

The Carnegie classification defines these schools as Baccalaureate Colleges: Diverse Fields, Baccalaureate/Associate's Colleges: Mixed Baccalaureate/Associate's Colleges, and Baccalaureate/Associate's Colleges: Associate's Dominant.

Specialty and other schools: There are a total of 191 specialty and other schools. These are colleges and universities that offer most or all of their degrees in [fine arts](#), [performing arts](#), [business](#), and [engineering and technology](#). U.S. News also includes on our website colleges and universities in these categories: faith, health, medical, special focus, research, tribal and other miscellaneous schools without a category. None of these schools are ranked, but pertinent data for each school is provided.

Specialty rankings of college majors: U.S. News also ranks certain undergraduate program areas. These six fields are among the biggest and most popular undergraduate majors in terms of the number of bachelor's degrees granted yearly. The rankings of [undergraduate business](#), [undergraduate engineering](#), [undergraduate computer science](#), [undergraduate nursing](#), [undergraduate economics](#) and [undergraduate psychology](#) programs were all based solely on separate peer assessment surveys conducted only among the programs in those specific fields in the spring and summer of 2024. Find out more details on each of the six specialty rankings and read the methodologies [here](#).

U.S. News Ranking Categories

The 1,634 regionally accredited schools in the overall Best Colleges rankings were divided into 10 categories based on the Carnegie Basic Classification. Of that total, 1,497 were ranked and 137 are listed as unranked.

The first chart below explains how the Carnegie Basic Classification categories translate into the categories used in the 2025 edition of the U.S. News Best Colleges rankings.

The next table has a complete breakdown of the number of schools in each category used in the 2025 overall rankings, as well as the number of schools in each category that are public, private or for-profit. The same table also shows the number of schools that are unranked in each category.

The third table gives the number of the schools or programs that ranked in specialty areas or popular college majors.

Carnegie Basic Classification Mapping to U.S. News Categories

CARNEGIE CATEGORY	U.S. NEWS CATEGORY
Doctoral Universities "very high research activity," Doctoral Universities "high research activity" and Doctoral/Professional Universities	National Universities
Master's Colleges and Universities (larger programs), Master's Colleges and Universities (medium programs), and Master's Colleges and Universities (smaller programs)	Regional Universities: North, South, Midwest and West
Baccalaureate Colleges—Arts and Sciences Focus	National Liberal Arts Colleges
Baccalaureate Colleges—Diverse Fields, Baccalaureate/Associate's Colleges: Mixed Baccalaureate/Associate's Colleges and Baccalaureate/Associate's Colleges: Associate's Dominant	Regional Colleges: North, South, Midwest and West



Counts by Specialty Ranking or Major

RANKED UNDERGRADUATE INSTITUTIONS IN THESE FIELDS	NUMBER OF SCHOOLS
Undergraduate business programs	532
Undergraduate computer science programs	584
Undergraduate engineering programs at schools where the highest degree in engineering is a Ph.D.	209
Undergraduate engineering programs at schools where the highest degree in engineering is a bachelor's or master's	286
Undergraduate nursing programs	686
Psychology	681
Economics	318



Counts by Ranking Category

CATEGORY	TOTAL NUMBER OF SCHOOLS	TOTAL NUMBER OF PUBLIC SCHOOLS	TOTAL NUMBER OF PRIVATE SCHOOLS	TOTAL NUMBER OF PROPRIETARY SCHOOLS	NUMBER IN CATEGORY THAT WERE UNRANKED	NUMBER OF RANKED SCHOOLS
National Universities	436	225	207	4	2	434
National Liberal Arts	211	19	192	0	7	204
Regional Universities (North)	172	62	105	5	7	165
Regional Universities (South)	135	58	71	6	2	133
Regional Universities (Midwest)	165	57	106	2	2	163
Regional Universities (West)	118	60	56	2	3	115
Regional Colleges (North)	68	35	28	5	8	60
Regional Colleges (South)	131	58	71	2	34	97
Regional Colleges (Midwest)	94	30	62	2	13	81
Regional Colleges (West)	104	74	24	6	59	45
Arts	37	4	31	2	37	0
Business	11	0	7	4	11	0
Engineering & Technology	5	0	5	0	5	0
Faith	20	0	20	0	20	0
Health	80	1	55	24	80	0
Medical	6	3	3	0	6	0
Special Focus	4	0	4	0	4	0
Research	11	11	0	0	11	0
Tribal	17	14	3	0	17	0
Regional Universities	590	237	338	15	14	576
Regional Colleges	397	197	185	15	114	283

Frequently Asked Questions: 2025 Best Colleges Rankings

Find answers to common queries about the U.S. News Best Colleges rankings.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

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Why U.S. News Ranks Colleges

1. Why rank colleges?

A college education is one of the most important – and one of the most costly – investments that prospective students will ever make.

For this reason, U.S. News believes students and their families should have as much information as possible about the comparative merits of the educational programs at America's [colleges and universities](#).

The data U.S. News gathers on colleges – and the rankings that arise from this data – serve as an objective guide for students and their parents to compare the academic quality of schools. They are designed as a tool for researching schools in combination with personal considerations and additional resources.

2. Are the rankings objective and fair?

Each school's rank within its group of peer institutions is based on the same set of quality measures. These measures focus exclusively on academics and graduate outcomes, which broadly matter to prospective students. Examples include graduation rates, indebtedness of graduates and student-faculty ratios.

The underlying data used to compute these measures was collected from third-party sources, and oftentimes reported directly by schools to U.S. News in alignment with what they recently reported to the government and/or following Common Data Set (CDS) initiative guidance. In other words, any rankings data schools reported directly to U.S. News adheres to industry-standard definitions and is reported to other entities.

While U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data, we take steps to review its accuracy through an iterative data collection process. When the surveys are being submitted, U.S. News algorithmically evaluates the data using prior cohort data to check for possible errors and consistency with related information. Afterward, U.S. News analysts examine schools' rankings data on a factor-by-factor level against their historical data, other schools' submissions and third-party sources. In some cases, U.S. News analysts have recontacted schools for explanations about their submissions.

Only 20% of the rankings is based on expert opinion, determined by a peer assessment from top academics at U.S. colleges. In the peer assessment survey, U.S. News asks the president, provost and dean of admissions at each school to rate the quality of the academic programs at schools in the same ranking category, including their own. Those unfamiliar with a particular school are asked to check a box labeled "don't know."

Peer assessments are qualitative information that complement the statistical data. For example, a diploma from a distinguished college can help a graduate get a job and gain admission to top-notch graduate programs.

3. Why are rankings helpful in choosing a college?

Rankings are helpful to applicants because they rate the strength of the academic program at each undergraduate institution. As such, the rankings give applicants information on key factors to consider when selecting a college.

Furthermore, the rankings are based on accepted measures of academic quality chosen after careful reporting and research on measuring quality in education. U.S. News takes pains to gather data in a uniform way and eliminate any gaps.

In addition, the rankings condense a great deal of information about the quality of education at each school, making it easier to compare institutions and select the best one for an individual. U.S. News administers its own data collection, which means much of the data published in its college directory is more current and comprehensive than what's available elsewhere. Prospective students can also use U.S. News' search tools to filter among schools that meet personalized criteria.

Finally, the rankings should not be the sole basis for prospective students or their parents to choose one school over another. The rankings should only be used as one factor in deciding where to attend school. Other key factors to consider include cost, location, extracurricular activities, financial aid and programs offered.

How U.S. News Ranks Colleges

1. In brief, how does U.S. News rank colleges?

To rank colleges, U.S. News first places each school into a category based on its mission and, in some cases, its geographic region of the U.S. – North, South, Midwest and West.

[National Universities](#), which focus on research and offer several doctoral programs, are ranked separately from [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#). And [Regional Universities](#) and [Regional Colleges](#) are compared with other schools in the same group and region.

Second, U.S. News gathers data from and about each school to measure academic excellence, using 17 factors for the National Universities. Each indicator is assigned a weight (expressed as a percentage) based on U.S. News' researched judgments about which measures of quality matter most. The other nine ranking categories have 13 ranking factors.

Third, colleges are ranked based on their overall scores. U.S. News publishes the individual ranks of the top 90% of schools in each category. The remaining 10% of schools display the bottom decile ranking ranges within their categories and are listed alphabetically.

Data for the 2025 edition of Best Colleges was gathered by U.S. News in the spring and summer of 2024.

2. Does U.S. News rank all U.S. colleges and universities?

No. Only regionally accredited institutions with four-year bachelor's degree-granting campus-based programs that enroll first-year (freshmen) students are surveyed and listed among U.S. schools in the Best Colleges rankings. Schools with no accreditation or only national accreditation do not appear in U.S. News' directory of Best Colleges and cannot be ranked. Institutions that only award bachelor's degrees as degree completion or only via distance education were also excluded (though they may have been ranked in the [2024 Best Online Bachelor's Programs](#) rankings).

Among colleges and universities listed in the directory, some are published as unranked for school-specific reasons. The most common reasons are either they were too specialized in a discipline (e.g., business schools) or they didn't have a six-year bachelor's degree graduation rate for first-time, first-year students.

In addition, a small number of schools are unranked because their total institutional enrollment was fewer than 100 students. In total, 137 out of the 1,634 schools in the 10 rank-eligible categories described below in question No. 5 are unranked because of these reasons. Unranked schools are listed alphabetically at the end of their respective categories.

An additional 191 U.S. schools among the more than 1,800 surveyed are grouped in categories that make them ineligible to be ranked. These are specialty institutions or schools without a category that in most cases offer most or all of their degrees in specialties such as fine arts, performing arts, business, engineering and technology, and health. However, certain eligible specialized schools can be ranked in U.S. News' separate undergraduate business, computer science, nursing, economics, psychology and engineering program rankings, and appear in other lists.

U.S. News has been handling unranked schools like this to some degree since 1990. U.S. News believes that because these schools are unable to report key educational characteristics or because they have certain other characteristics, it would be unfair to try to compare them statistically with the other schools that are part of the rankings.

3. Why does the methodology change most years?

U.S. News refines its methodology for one simple reason: to improve it. There is an active and ongoing debate about how best to measure quality in education, and U.S. News pays close attention to that debate. When new or better ideas for measuring quality are proposed or when new data becomes available, U.S. News evaluates them carefully and makes changes where it deems appropriate.

Analysts at U.S. News communicate with schools, organize advisory panels, attend conferences, deliver webinars, review higher education literature, incorporate user feedback and study trends in their survey data to refine the methodologies.

For example, over time, the ranking model has put far less emphasis on input measures of quality – which look at characteristics of the students, faculty and other resources going into the educational process – and put more emphasis on output measures, which look at the results of the educational process. This shift was consistent with the increased emphasis that educators, researchers and policymakers have placed on results when comparing and evaluating educational programs.

4. What changes, if any, were made this year to the methodology and the rankings?

U.S. News made a few changes to the methodology for the 2025 edition of the Best Colleges rankings. For a thorough explanation of these changes, the weights and the indicators used, see the [methodology article](#). For an even deeper dive into how we computed the ranking indicators, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)" and the [Morse Code: Inside the College Rankings](#) post.

5. Why does U.S. News classify colleges into different categories before ranking them? How are the categories defined?

The purpose of grouping colleges into categories is to make valid comparisons of schools with similar missions. For example, schools that offer graduate programs and emphasize research are generally structured differently and are less comparable on some resource-focused ranking indicators that relate to schools' academic missions.

To define the categories for the 2025 Best Colleges rankings, for the third consecutive year, we used the 2021 update to the Carnegie Classification of Institutions of Higher Education's [Basic Classification](#), the most widely accepted classification system in higher education.

U.S. News collapses some of the Carnegie Basic categories into four: [National Universities](#), [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#), [Regional Universities](#) and [Regional Colleges](#). Regional Universities and Regional Colleges are placed into one of four geographic categories: North, South, Midwest and West. In total, there are 10 Best Colleges ranking categories.

6. What are National Universities?

National Universities offer a full range of undergraduate majors as well as master's and doctoral degrees. In many cases, they place strong emphasis on research and receive federal money to support their research endeavors.

There are 436 National Universities – 225 public, 207 private and four for-profit – based on the categories that the Carnegie Classification of Institutions of Higher Education establishes.

7. What are National Liberal Arts Colleges?

National Liberal Arts Colleges emphasize undergraduate education. To be included in this category, colleges must award at least 50% of their degrees in liberal arts disciplines, such as languages and literature, biology and life sciences, philosophy, cultural studies, and psychology.

There are 211 National Liberal Arts Colleges – 192 private, 19 public and zero for-profit schools.

8. What are Regional Universities and Regional Colleges?

Like National Universities, Regional Universities offer a full range of undergraduate programs and provide graduate education at the master's level. However, they differ by offering few, if any, doctoral programs. Of the 590 Regional Universities, 237 are public, 338 are private and 15 are for-profit.

The 397 Regional Colleges – including 197 public institutions, 185 private schools and 15 for-profits – focus on undergraduate education but grant fewer than 50% of their degrees in liberal arts disciplines. The Regional Colleges category includes some institutions where only a small number of degrees awarded are at the bachelor's level.

Regional Universities and Regional Colleges are placed into one of four geographic categories: North, South, Midwest and West.

9. What measures of academic quality does U.S. News use in its rankings?

The Best Colleges rankings assess academic quality. Nonacademic considerations – such as campus safety, athletics and access to college-owned housing – are not factored, although certain nonacademic profile data like this is published in schools' directory pages on usnews.com.

Only statistical measures of academic quality are used to calculate the rankings. The rankings do not account for nonacademic factors like campus environment.

The indicators include input measures, which reflect the quality of students, faculty and other resources used in education, and outcome measures, such as six-year graduation and first-year student retention rates, graduate indebtedness, and graduation rate performance, which signal how well the institution educates its student body.

For a thorough explanation of these changes, the weights and the indicators used, see the [methodology article](#). For an even deeper dive into how we computed the ranking indicators, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)" and the [Morse Code: Inside the College Rankings](#) blog post.

10. Where does the data used in the rankings come from?

Schools report most of the information directly to U.S. News. Each year, U.S. News sends an extensive questionnaire to all accredited four-year colleges and universities. U.S. News, a founding member of the Common Data Set initiative, incorporates questions from the CDS and proprietary questions on this survey. U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data.

Data collection for the 2025 edition of Best Colleges took place during spring and summer 2024. When the surveys are returned, U.S. News evaluates the data, using prior cohort data and third-party sources to check for possible errors and consistency with related information. For example, SAT scores must fall in a particular range, and the score reported as the 25th percentile must be less than the score reported as the 75th percentile. U.S. News reports flagged data to schools and gives them an opportunity to review, revise and verify the data.

In the case of colleges that did not fill out this year's U.S. News statistical survey or don't answer all the questions on the survey and are ranked in the 2025 Best Colleges, U.S. News made extensive use of the statistical data those institutions were required to report to the U.S. Department of Education's National Center for Education Statistics. These required data points include such factors as SAT and ACT scores, faculty counts and salaries, enrollment, financial resources, graduation rates for all students, Pell Grant student graduation rates, non-Pell Grant student graduation rates and first-year retention rates. The data

for graduate indebtedness and percent of graduates earning more than high school graduates uses data from the U.S. Department of Education's College Scorecard, a portal that consolidates and provides downloadable information from across the department's offices.

In addition, the faculty quality research metrics used only in the National Universities ranking come from Elsevier. Elsevier, a global leader in information and analytics, helps researchers and health care professionals advance science and improve health outcomes for the benefit of society. It does this by facilitating insights and critical decision-making for customers across the global research and health ecosystems. To learn more, visit its [website](#).

11. Which measure of quality is most important?

Each measure that U.S. News uses in its rankings captures some important dimension of the academic program. The weight, expressed as a percentage, tells you the relative importance that U.S. News places on each measure.

The U.S. News formula puts an emphasis on outcomes, evidenced by measures of graduation and retention being the most heavily weighted factors in the Best Colleges rankings.

U.S. News made some small changes to the methodology for the 2025 edition of the Best Colleges rankings. For a thorough explanation of these changes, the weights and the indicators used, see the [methodology article](#). For an even deeper dive into how we computed the ranking indicators, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)" and the [Morse Code: Inside the College Rankings](#) blog post.

Overall, the factors that directly relate to social mobility, graduation and retention rates, graduate indebtedness, graduate earnings compared with earnings of high school graduates, and graduation rate performance have a total weight of more than 50% in the ranking methodology, far outweighing any other factor in the rankings.

The U.S. News rankings formula gives a weight of 20% to academic reputation scores because a diploma from a distinguished college can help graduates get jobs or gain admission to top-notch graduate programs.

U.S. News recommends that prospective students consider which ranking factors are especially important to them and look at those individual elements as well as a school's overall rank. Our search and sort capabilities make it easy to locate schools that are strong in a particular area.

12. How did U.S. News decide how much weight to give each ranking factor in its formula?

Analysts at U.S. News choose the weights used in the ranking formula. These views of the appropriate weights may differ from those of other higher education experts. Weights were chosen based on years of reporting about education, literature reviews, consultation with experts in higher education, conferences, advisory panels, user feedback, and examination of trends in internal and external data available.

Over time, U.S. News has placed greater weight on the outcome measures of quality, such as graduation rates, graduation rate performance and social mobility, and de-emphasized admissions data and dropped from the current rankings input measures such as acceptance rates and alumni giving rates.

These decisions are consistent with education experts' growing emphasis on outcomes in assessing the performance of complex institutions such as colleges.

13. Can schools improve their rankings by soliciting more applications or improving their yields?

Definitely not. Starting with the 2019 Best Colleges rankings, acceptance rate is no longer factored into schools' overall ranks. This means schools receive no direct benefit in the rankings by increasing total applicants or rejecting applicants. Yield (the proportion of students who enroll after being offered admittance) has not been used in the rankings since the 2003 edition.

14. Why did my school's rank go up – or down – this year?

Each school's circumstances are different, but U.S. News can tell you in general terms why rank changes took place in the 2025 Best Colleges rankings. U.S. News made a few changes to the methodology for this year's rankings edition, mainly in the National Universities category.

In some cases, schools changed rank in this edition due to the 2025 methodology changes.

Another primary factor behind why a school moved up or down in the rankings is because some or all of the data it reported that was factored into the rankings moved higher or lower when compared with the previous year's data. A college's overall rank may change from one year to the next when its data varies either upward or downward on one or more measures of academic quality that U.S. News uses in the rankings. Even if the data didn't change, a school's position when measured relative to one or more of its peers in its ranking category may have changed.

In other words, a school's rank can vary because its performance on a measure such as graduation and retention rates changes or because the performance of other schools in the same peer group on a measure such as graduation and retention rates changes.

In some cases, schools reported more – or in some cases less – complete data on the U.S. News statistical survey used to compile the 2025 Best Colleges rankings compared with what they reported on the statistical surveys used in the previous ranking. A change in how schools report their data from one year to the next is one factor in why some schools moved up or down in the rankings.

All of these factors aside, sometimes there is not a definitive performance-based reason why a school's rank changed. Something seemingly minor – such as whether a school rounded up or down to create its overall score – could impact its rank by a number of places because of ties. In other words, some year-to-year volatility is to be expected.

15. Do private schools fare better than public schools in the U.S. News rankings?

The methodology in the 2025 rankings for some schools in some factors may benefit some public schools more than private schools. Public schools tend to do well in social mobility and other outcomes factors.

Overall though, private colleges and universities tend to do better on several measures in the U.S. News ranking model, including SAT/ACT scores, graduation and retention rates, and faculty resources.

In addition, public colleges and universities tend to have lower graduation and retention rates than private schools, and many public schools often lack the financial resources that some private universities have.

Note: U.S. News publishes separate rankings of the [Top Public Schools](#) in each category.

16. Why doesn't U.S. News rank undergraduate specialty schools like those in arts, engineering, business or other specialty institutions?

Of the more than 1,800 institutions U.S. News surveyed, 191 fall into a specialty category because they award most or all of their degrees in fine arts, performing arts, business, engineering or other fields.

These schools offer an important alternative for students aspiring to have careers in particular fields. U.S. News provides pertinent data for each school but does not rank these institutions because there are too few in each category to allow a fair comparison and because their specialized focus would require a different system of ranking.

However, U.S. News does annually rank some of the largest undergraduate majors. This year, U.S. News ranked:

- 532 undergraduate [business programs](#) accredited by AACSB International
- 495 undergraduate [engineering programs](#) accredited by ABET
- 686 [Bachelor of Science in Nursing](#) programs accredited at the bachelor's level by either the Commission on Collegiate Nursing Education or the Accreditation Commission for Education in Nursing
- 584 [undergraduate computer science programs](#)
- 318 [undergraduate economics programs](#)
- 681 [undergraduate psychology programs](#)

These overall business, engineering, nursing, computer science, economics and psychology rankings are based solely on peer assessment surveys that were sent in the spring and summer of 2024. The results of these separate surveys are available on [usnews.com](#). U.S. News also ranks specialties in business, engineering and computer sciences. These specialty areas, such as civil engineering, gaming and accounting, are also based solely on results from this year's peer assessment surveys.

17. Does U.S. News consider economic diversity or socioeconomic status in its rankings?

Yes, U.S. News factors economic diversity and socioeconomic status into the rankings. This is done primarily by using various performance measures relating to students receiving Pell Grants, which play an important role in the U.S. News rankings and are the basis for how U.S. News measures social mobility.

Starting with the 2019 edition, we factored a school's success at promoting social mobility by graduating students who received federal Pell Grants by adding these two ranking indicators: Pell Grant graduation rates and Pell Grant graduation rates compared with all other students. Students who receive federal Pell Grants typically come from households whose family incomes are less than \$50,000 annually, though most Pell Grant money goes to students with total family incomes below \$20,000. For all the ranking categories, the two Pell graduation rate ranking factors weigh 5.5% each.

In addition, U.S. News continues to include the proportion of the student body receiving Pell Grants in its graduation rate performance formula, which has a weight of 10% in the rankings and is used in all U.S. News ranking categories. Pell Grants are an important indicator of how many low-income students attend a school, and adding them results in a model that better captures the school's student body.

In total, economic diversity-related indicators are now used in ranking factors that account for 21% of the 2025 edition of the Best Colleges rankings.

More about Pell Grants can be found in the [Economic Diversity](#) table.

18. What does it mean when a school has a numerical ranking range or is listed as unranked?

U.S. News displays numerical ranking ranges for schools in the bottom 10% of the National Universities, National Liberal Arts Colleges, Regional Universities, Regional Colleges, and Historically Black Colleges and Universities categories based on their overall score. For the two engineering program rankings and the undergraduate business, computer science, nursing, economics, and psychology program rankings, schools or programs with an average peer assessment score less than 2.0 are listed in a numerical ranking range based on the numerical rankings of each of the respective rankings that have a peer assessment score less than 2.0.

Schools with a numerical ranking range in the main rankings of the National Universities, National Liberal Arts Colleges, Regional Universities, Regional Colleges, and Historically Black Colleges and Universities categories are different from schools labeled as unranked. Schools with a ranking range in their category have numerical ranks that U.S. News has decided for editorial reasons not to publish. U.S. News publishes numerical ranks for only the top 90% of schools in each ranking category.

U.S. News will supply schools listed with a numerical ranking range in their category with their numerical rank, overall score and indicator rankings if they submit a request following the procedures listed on the [Information for School Officials](#) page. Schools with a numerical ranking range in their category are listed alphabetically.

Unranked means the school did not qualify to be numerically ranked by U.S. News, and therefore U.S. News did not calculate a numerical rank for that school. Schools marked as unranked are listed alphabetically and below those marked with numerical ranking ranges.

U.S. News believes that because schools listed as unranked are unable to report key educational characteristics, such as a six-year bachelor's degree graduation rate, it would be unfair to compare them statistically with the other schools that are part of the rankings since factors related to the six-year graduation rate count for more than one-third of the rankings.

There is a more detailed explanation above and in the [main methodology](#) for why a school is listed as unranked.

19. How does U.S. News handle for-profits in the rankings?

All regionally accredited for-profit institutions are included in U.S. News' data collection efforts. Among them are many schools that have large [online bachelor's degree programs](#).

Any for-profit college or university that grants bachelor's degrees, is regionally accredited, and meets the other specific U.S. News ranking criteria to be included in the Best Colleges rankings can be ranked. Once again, U.S. News has included test-blind schools in the rankings, which has resulted in more for-profit schools being ranked. Many for-profits and a growing number of nonprofits don't use SAT or ACT test scores in admissions decisions.

20. How does U.S. News handle schools that refuse to respond to the U.S. News annual statistical survey, given that many of them are still included in the rankings?

Nonresponders are still included in the rankings if they are eligible to be ranked. For schools that were eligible to be ranked but did not fill out the U.S. News statistical survey in spring and summer 2024, U.S. News footnoted them as such on their profile pages on [usnews.com](#), and made extensive use of the statistical data those institutions were required to report to the U.S. Department of Education's National Center for Education Statistics and the College Scorecard as the basis for their ranking.

That includes such factors as SAT and ACT scores, number of faculty, six-year graduation rates, percentage of graduates earning more than a high school graduate, Pell Grant graduation rates, graduate indebtedness, faculty salaries, financial expenditures, and first-year student retention rates.

Schools that submitted their surveys but did not have a top school official sign off on their accuracy are also footnoted.

21. How can I find the rank of a particular school?

U.S. News publishes the rankings in two places: in a college guidebook, "Best Colleges 2025," and on this website, which also offers the [U.S. News College Compass](#) – home to the most complete rankings and data. The guidebook is available for purchase at online and physical bookstores, by calling 800-836-6397 or by visiting the [U.S. News store](#). For discounts on bulk orders of 50 or more copies, please contact booksales@usnews.com.

If you are using the college guidebook – the only print version of the rankings – the index, where schools are listed alphabetically, gives page numbers of any table in which a particular school appears. The index also shows the page number for the school's entry in the directory, which is filled with facts about each college and university.

The U.S. News website has the most complete data and, in some cases, more extended rankings than are published in the guidebook. If you are using the website's [college search](#), simply type in the school's name and/or state, and the results will take you to the online directory. The website has additional search and sort features to help customize a college search.

If you can't find a particular school, make sure you are looking under the right category. The school may be too small or too specialized to be ranked – although we do provide data on these institutions in the guidebook and online.

Those interested in the most comprehensive data on each school and the most extensive rankings in each category can subscribe to the U.S. News College Compass.

22. Can I find out all of a school's U.S. News rankings in one place?

Each school has a Rankings tab on the top of its profile page on [usnews.com](#) that allows you to see all the Best Colleges categories in which that school currently is ranked. If the school is in other U.S. News education rankings – such as Best Graduate Schools, Best Online Programs and Best Global Universities – you can access those ranks from this page as well.

Historically Black Colleges Rankings Methodology

U.S. News ranked a total of 77 historically Black colleges and universities.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

For prospective students who value the community atmosphere and networking opportunities associated with [historically Black colleges and universities](#), this ranking measures the quality of the undergraduate education at these institutions.

To be included, a school must currently be listed as part of the [White House and U.S. Department of Education's Initiative](#) on Advancing Educational Equity, Excellence and Economic Opportunity through Historically Black Colleges and Universities. The Higher Education Act of 1965 [defines an HBCU as](#):

"any historically Black college or university that was established prior to 1964, whose principal mission was, and is, the education of Black Americans, and that is accredited by a nationally recognized accrediting agency or association determined by the Secretary (of Education) to be a reliable authority as to the quality of training offered or is, according to such an agency or association, making reasonable progress toward accreditation."

These HBCUs were compared only with one another. In other words, this ranking is not simply U.S. News' overall rankings filtered among HBCUs. Instead it was produced from standalone computations in which HBCUs had their statistics compared only against each other to produce the normalized values used in assigning ranks.

The formula is also distinct from the overall rankings by having only incorporated the ratings of top officials exclusively at HBCUs regarding the academic quality of other HBCUs. This approach was intended to produce more especially refined assessments of these institutions than obtained in the overall rankings because of the greater familiarity that HBCUs have with each other.

For an HBCU to qualify for this ranking, it must be a regionally accredited institution that enrolls first-year students into four-year baccalaureate programs, among other criteria. If an HBCU is listed as unranked in this year's overall rankings, it is also listed as unranked in the HBCU rankings. See the article, ["How U.S. News Calculated the 2025 College Rankings"](#) for details on ranking eligibility and general information on how the rankings were calculated.

In total, 77 HBCUs that were eligible to be included on the list were ranked. One eligible HBCU is listed as unranked. Among the 77 ranked HBCUs, schools that place in the top 90% display their individual ranks. The remaining bottom 10% of ranked schools display the bottom decile numerical ranking range and are listed alphabetically.

U.S. News used the same data in the HBCU rankings that was used in the 2025 edition of the Best Colleges rankings, except for the peer survey results, which were based on a separate HBCU peer assessment survey.

The U.S. News rankings system rests on two pillars: quantitative and qualitative measures that education experts have proposed as reliable indicators of academic quality, and U.S. News' view of what matters in education.

The HBCU rankings are based on nearly the same statistical indicators as were used in the Regional ranking categories in the 2025 Best Colleges rankings. The following are detailed descriptions of the statistical indicators and weights that U.S. News used to measure academic quality among the ranked HBCUs.

Outcomes

Outcome ranking indicators determine more than half of a school's rank, and they are: success at retaining and graduating students within a six-year time frame, social mobility, earnings of graduates compared with high school graduates, and graduate indebtedness. Graduation rates receive the highest weight in the rankings because degree completion is necessary to receive the full benefits of undergraduate study from employers and graduate schools. We approach measuring college graduation from diverse angles in terms of the indicators that are used.

Graduation and retention rates: This important measure has two separate components.

Average six-year graduation rate (16%): The graduation rate indicates the average proportion of a class that earns a degree in six years or less; U.S. News considers first-year classes that started from fall 2014 through fall 2017.

Average first-year student retention rate (5%): First-year student retention indicates the average proportion of first-year students entering each fall from 2019 through 2022 who returned the following fall.

Social mobility: We factored a school's success at promoting social mobility by graduating students who received federal Pell Grants (those typically coming from households whose family incomes are less than \$50,000 annually, though most Pell Grant money goes to students with a total family income below \$20,000).

Pell graduation rates (8.5%, previously 5%): This measures the success of Pell Grant students on an absolute basis. To calculate this indicator, we used a school's six-year graduation rate for a four-year moving average among new fall 2014 through fall 2017 entrants receiving Pell Grants. This assesses each school's performance graduating students from low-income backgrounds. A higher Pell Grant graduation rate scores better than a lower one.

Pell graduation performance (8.5%, previously 5%): This ranking factor compares each school's six-year graduation rate among Pell Grant recipients with its six-year graduation rate among non-Pell recipients using a four-year average of new fall 2014 through fall 2017 entrants graduating in six years. The significant minority of schools whose Pell graduation rates are equal to or greater than non-Pell graduation rates score the highest, with lower scores for remaining schools depending upon how much lower the Pell graduation rate is compared to the non-Pell graduation rate.

Scores for both these two social mobility indicators were adjusted by the proportion of the entering class that was awarded Pell Grants because achieving a higher low-income student graduation rate is more challenging with a larger proportion of low-income students.

In the last edition, the graduation rates of first-generation students were incorporated into the overall HBCU rankings. They were dropped this year based on clarification about the limitations of the U.S. Department of Education's College Scorecard data in some cases. The entire weight from first-generation indicators was added equally to the two Pell Grant graduation rate indicators described above.

Graduate indebtedness (9%): This is an outcomes factor which assesses each school's typical average accumulated federal loan debt among borrowers only. Graduates who covered their expenses without borrowing did not help or hurt schools. The data was sourced from the College Scorecard. The calculation averaged 2019-2020 and 2020-2021 data because data on 2021-2022 graduates had not been released at the time of the 2025 HBCU rankings finalization. For more information, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)."

College grads earning more than a high school graduate (5%): This assesses the proportion of a school's federal loan recipients who graduated in the 2014-2015 or the 2015-2016 academic years and five years later – in 2020 or 2021 – were earning more than a typical high school graduate salary, as determined by, and reported in, the College Scorecard. This was the same graduating class cohort years used in the previous year's HBCU rankings, but this time their earnings five years after graduation were assessed instead of four years after graduation; and therefore 95% instead 90% was assigned as the marker for a perfect score. For more information, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)."

Peer assessment (20%): This measure gives weight to the opinions of those in a position to judge a school's undergraduate academic excellence. The peer assessment survey allows the top HBCU academics whom U.S. News consults to account for intangibles, such as faculty dedication to teaching.

Each individual is asked to rate academic programs of peer HBCUs on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). Those who don't know enough about a school to evaluate it fairly were asked to mark "don't know."

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News conducted an exclusive peer survey of the president, provost and admissions dean at each HBCU. Each HBCU received three surveys. U.S. News asked the recipients to rate all HBCUs they were familiar with based on undergraduate academic quality, considering each school's scholarship record, curriculum, and quality of faculty and graduates.

To calculate the overall HBCU rankings, U.S. News used the two most recent years' responses instead of only the most recent year. This was done to incorporate greater representation of the views of academics at HBCUs and to decrease the year-to-year volatility of the results in the peer reputation ranking factor.

The response rate for the spring and summer 2024 survey of top officials at HBCUs was 18.4%. This is compared with the 24% of top officials who responded to the spring 2023 HBCU peer assessment survey.

Whether a school submitted a peer assessment survey or statistical survey had no impact on the average peer score it received from other schools. However, HBCUs that did not respond to U.S. News' statistical

survey who submitted HBCU peer surveys had their ratings of other schools excluded from the computations.

Faculty resources: Research shows that the greater access students have to quality instructors, the more engaged they will be in class and the more they will learn. Research also shows that the more satisfied students are about their contact with professors, the more they will learn and the more likely they are to graduate. U.S. News uses three factors from the 2023-2024 academic year to assess a school's commitment to instruction.

Faculty salary (8%): This assesses the average salaries for the 2023-2024 academic year, excluding benefits, for full-time instructional faculty using definitions from the American Association of University Professors. Salary data was adjusted for regional differences in the cost of living using the U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis regional price parities indexes, published in December 2023.

Student-faculty ratio (4%): This is the ratio of undergraduate students to instructional faculty.

Proportion of faculty who are full time (3%): This compares the counts of full-time faculty to part-time faculty who are teaching courses, with a higher proportion of faculty teaching full-time receiving credit.

Financial resources (8%): Generous per-student spending indicates that a college can offer a variety of programs and services. U.S. News measures financial resources by using the average spending per student on instruction, research, student services and related educational expenditures in the 2022 fiscal year. The expenditures data was sourced directly from the IPEDS finance survey. Expenditures were compared with 2021-2022 academic year full-time equivalent total enrollment to produce a per-student figure. The enrollment data was sourced from the IPEDS fall enrollment survey. Spending on sports, dorms and hospitals doesn't count; U.S. News only considers the part of a school's budget that goes toward educating students. The source of the data for all schools for this ranking indicator was the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System \(IPEDS\) Data Center](#).

SAT/ACT scores (5%): U.S. News factors in enrollees' test scores on the mathematics and evidence-based reading and writing portions of the SAT and the composite ACT (5%). Data is for the fall 2023 entering class and is based on the scores students submitted that were used in the admissions process.

The SAT/ACT ranking indicator for HBCUs was calculated using the same methodology as is used in the overall Best Colleges rankings. This means median test scores on the SAT and ACT were converted to percentile distributions and weighted by the proportion of new entrants that submitted the SAT vs. ACT exams. Schools reporting on less than half of new entrants were scored on their previous year's data if reported on at least half. Schools reporting on less than half of their new entrants two years in a row had the ranking factor's 5% weight reallocated to the average graduation rate ranking factors, because this factor had one of the highest correlations with SAT/ACT scores.

For more details on how standardized test scores were used in the rankings, see the article, "[A More Detailed Look at the Ranking Factors](#)."

Data Sources

Most of the data comes from the colleges. While U.S. News relies on the colleges to accurately report their data, steps were taken to review its accuracy. For quality assurance, rankings data that schools reported to U.S. News was algorithmically compared against previous years' submissions to detect possible inaccuracies. Respondents were required to review, possibly revise and verify any flagged data before they could submit their surveys, as well as explain in writing any large changes. Afterward, the data submitted was reviewed by U.S. News data analysts and subject to further requests for schools to confirm or revise the data. U.S. News required that a top official at each school verify the accuracy of the submitted data.

U.S. News obtained missing data from the IPEDS Data Center for such factors as six-year graduation rates, retention rates, SAT and ACT scores, faculty counts, faculty salaries, student-teacher ratios, and the [College Scorecard](#) for graduate indebtedness and the percentage of college graduates earning more than a high school graduate.

Missing data pertaining to statistics U.S. News collected in its most recent survey is reported as "N/A" in the rankings and school profile pages on usnews.com. See the article, "[How U.S. News Collects Best Colleges Data](#)" for more

How to Use the 2025 U.S. News Best Colleges Directory

U.S. News provides key statistics for more than 1,800 colleges and universities.

By Robert Morse, Eric Brooks and Kenneth Hines

Note: The complete directory and related statistics, including some that are listed below, are only available in the [U.S. News College Compass](#).

On this site, you can find exhaustive profiles of more than 1,800 colleges and universities that U.S. News & World Report surveys each year. This online version of the directory allows you to find useful information to help you choose which colleges might be right for you.

The vital statistics shown in each directory entry are explained below. U.S. News collected data from schools during the spring and summer of 2024. If a college did not supply the data requested, it says "N/A," for "not available." Otherwise, when schools did not return the full U.S. News statistical questionnaire, data reported in the previous year or to the U.S. Department of Education may be displayed. The data reflects information U.S. News received as of August 26, 2024.

The directory can help you identify schools that meet your needs. Here's a rundown of the different sections and some key information contained in each school profile.

If a school didn't respond to the U.S. News statistical survey during the spring and summer 2024 data collection cycle, it has this footnote on its school name: [1] This school declined to fill out the U.S. News & World Report main statistical survey in 2024. Data that appears is from either what the school reported in previous years or from another source, such as the [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) Data Center and the [College Scorecard](#), both of which are part of the U.S. Department of Education.

Overview and Quick Stats

Check out the school's address, determine the cost of attendance, see how many undergraduate students are enrolled and get the latest acceptance rate for those who applied. The application deadline shown is for the academic year starting in fall 2025; while a school with rolling admissions makes decisions as it receives applications until it has filled the class.

Figures cited for tuition, food and housing, and required fees are, in almost all cases, for the 2024-2025 academic year. For public schools, U.S. News lists both in-state and out-of-state tuition. If data for the 2024-2025 academic year is not available, U.S. News provides figures from the 2023-2024 academic year.

In addition to school-provided statistics, hundreds of college directory pages have summaries that provide insight into student life at the school. Discover what clubs and organizations you can join, what sports teams to cheer for and how many majors a school offers. You may also find whether students are required to live on campus and what there is to do off campus.

Rankings

Each school has a Rankings tab near the top left of its profile page that displays all the different [Best Colleges](#) categories in which that school is ranked. If the school is also in other U.S. News education rankings – Best Graduate Schools, Best Online Programs and Best Global Universities, for example – you can access those ranks from this page as well by scrolling down the page.

Admissions

Along with application deadlines for fall 2025 admissions – for regular decision, early decision and early action – you can find a link to each school's online application.

This section also includes an institution's high school academic requirements, plus whether it requires SAT or ACT scores, and whether it uses these scores in admissions decisions. Various academic and nonacademic factors that are, or might be, considered in admissions decisions are rated on their relative importance as "very important," "important," "considered" or "not considered."

A look at admissions statistics for the fall 2023 entering class of first-year students tells you the proportion of all applicants who were accepted, as well as the proportion of early decision and early action applicants who got in compared with the acceptance rate of nonearly applicants. You can find out how many first-year students enrolled, what percentage was accepted early and how many were men, women or another gender, if the school has such data available.

There's also the percentage of first-year students who submitted their high school class standing when they applied and how many ranked among the top 10%, top quarter, top half and bottom quarter of their high school graduating class.

U.S. News supplies the average high school grade-point average of the 2023 first-year students, the percentage submitting SAT and ACT scores, and, for both tests, the range within which half the students scored.

The 25th-75th percentile ranges shown for enrollees' test scores on both the mathematics and evidence-based reading and writing portions of the SAT or the composite ACT tell you that 25% of students scored at or below the lower end of the range and 25% scored at or above the upper end.

Students thinking of transferring can quickly find out in this section when to apply and what the admissions requirements are – whether a high school transcript is necessary as well as a college transcript, for example, and whether an essay or admissions interview is required or recommended.

What is the required minimum high school GPA and the minimum college GPA? What is the lowest course grade that can be transferred for credit? What is the maximum number of credits or courses that can be transferred? U.S. News also provides the number of transfer applications received for fall 2023, the number of transfer applicants who were offered admission and the number who enrolled.

Cost

This section covers a school's tuition and financial aid. One statistic you surely want to know about any school you're considering is the sticker price, or the nondiscounted price: tuition, food and housing, and required fees. We give figures for the 2024-2025 academic year. For public schools, we list both in-state and out-of-state tuition, food and housing, and required fees.

If data for the 2024-2025 academic year is not available, we show figures from 2023-2024. U.S. News also provides estimates of the cost of books and supplies, transportation, and personal expenses for the 2024-2025 academic year. In some cases, a comprehensive fee is listed, which includes tuition, food and housing, and certain other expenses.

You can also find details about working while in school. During the 2023-2024 academic year, what proportion of undergraduates worked on campus? How much can undergraduates expect to earn per year from part-time, on-campus work?

In addition, a link to each school's [net price calculator](#) is listed; this can help students determine how much it costs to attend the school and whether they qualify for need-based [financial aid](#).

Anyone planning to apply for financial aid for fall 2025 can find an overview of necessary forms and deadlines:

- Which types of need-based scholarships and grants are available to students?
- What criteria is used in awarding institutional need-based aid?
- What criteria is used in awarding institutional non-need-based aid?
- What loan programs are available?
- What tuition payment plans are open to undergraduates?

The data on financial aid packages given to undergraduates during the 2023-2024 school year includes the percentage of undergraduates who applied for aid, the percentage determined by the school to have financial need and what percentage had their need fully met by an aid package that excluded parent or other private loans.

In addition, U.S. News lists the average financial aid package (including grants, loans and jobs) and the proportion of students receiving a package; the average amount of gift aid (scholarships or grants) and the proportion receiving such aid; the average amount of self-help aid (work study or loans) and the proportion receiving such aid; and the average need-based student loan.

Among students who received need-based aid, what percentage of their need was met, on average? U.S. News also includes information on merit awards and the average debt burden of 2022 graduates who borrowed.

U.S. News included data from the [College Scorecard](#) in the Tuition and Financial Aid sections of each school's directory. These data points include the average annual cost for students receiving need-based federal financial aid, the same average cost broken down by family income level, the percentage of students receiving federal loans, federal loan debt amounts by family income level, median federal debt

after graduation, typical monthly loan payments after graduation, typical monthly debt among students who didn't graduate, the percentage of students paying down their debt after graduation and the percentage of students paying down their debt after graduation by family income level.

Academics

Information on faculty for the 2023-2024 academic year includes the number of full-time professors and the breakdown of men, women, minorities and international faculty members. You can also see what percentage have earned a doctorate or other terminal degree in their field.

The ratio of undergraduates to undergraduate faculty is provided, as is the percentage of class sections taught by graduate teaching assistants. Class size figures tell you the percentage of classes during the fall 2023 term that had fewer than 20 students, the percentage with 20 to 49 students, and the percentage with 50 or more. Labs and discussion sections are excluded.

Two key numbers that applicants should consider are a school's first-year retention rate and its graduation rate. The average first-year retention rate tells you the average proportion of first-year students who started in fall 2019 through fall 2022 and returned the following fall. The graduation rates show the proportion of first-year, first-time students starting college in fall 2017 who earned a bachelor's degree in four, five and six years.

You can see the number of degrees by level (including bachelor's, master's and doctorate) or certificates awarded between July 1, 2022, and June 30, 2023.

Degrees offered are noted, and you can see a list of up to the 10 most popular majors among 2023 graduates, with the percentage of students who majored in them. You also have the ability to search all the majors offered by the school that lead to a degree. Majors are arranged by category and are listed alphabetically within categories.

The availability of other types of academic programs – including pre-professional, teacher certification and cooperative education programs; learning communities; and study abroad – are also noted.

If specific courses are required for graduation, they appear in this section.

Student Body

What will your classmates be like? This section supplies the breakdown of full- and part-time students, the gender distribution of enrollments, the racial and ethnic makeup of the student body, the out-of-state population, the percentage of students living on campus, and the percentage who participate in fraternities and sororities. This section also lists whether a school offers ROTC. Data including the percentage of students who are first-generation college students (first in their family to attend college) is listed as well.

All figures are for the 2023-2024 academic year. Note that numbers may not add up to 100% because of rounding.

Housing and residence halls: Learn what types of college-owned, -operated or -affiliated housing are available for undergraduates on campus and whether students are required to live in campus housing.

Sports: This section contains information about the school's intercollegiate varsity, club and intramural sports programs. Is the school a member of either the National Collegiate Athletic Association or the National Association of Intercollegiate Athletics? During the 2023-2024 academic year, how many intercollegiate varsity sports – and which ones – were offered for men and women?

Clubs and organizations: You can get a sense of the extracurricular opportunities on campus from a list of major clubs and organizations and numbers of fraternities and sororities, including the proportion of undergraduates who are members of them. All information is for the 2023-2024 academic year.

Campus safety: This section contains the data that each [school reported](#) to the U.S. Department of Education covering criminal offenses and arrests on campus in student housing facilities and in other areas that students use. The statistics cover three years: 2020, 2021 and 2022. Keep in mind that the numbers for criminal offenses reflect reports of alleged offenses to campus security and/or law enforcement authorities, not necessarily prosecutions or convictions. Campus safety information is not available for all schools – for example, schools that do not participate in federal financial aid programs are not required by U.S. law to report this data. Experts advise prospective students and their families to [do their own research](#) to evaluate the safety of a campus and the surrounding area.

Campus Life

This section says whether students are permitted to have cars on campus, which student services are offered – counseling services, remediation and career-placement services, for example – and lets you know if there are museums or special academic buildings on campus.

Campus security services are enumerated, too. All information is for the 2023-2024 academic year.

Disabled students: Students with learning disabilities can find out whether a school offers a specific program for them and what services for learning-disabled students are available. Likewise, physically disabled students can find out about services provided and whether campus housing specifically for disabled students is available. All information is for the 2023-2024 academic year.

Ranking Factors

A school's rank indicates where it sits among its peers in the 2025 edition of the U.S. News Best Colleges rankings. There's a description that indicates which category of institution the school falls into, as well as its rank within the group. The categories are [National Universities](#), [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#), [Regional Universities](#) and [Regional Colleges](#).

The Regional Universities and Regional Colleges categories are further subdivided by location: North, South, West and Midwest.

All colleges in the National Universities, National Liberal Arts Colleges, Regional Universities and Regional Colleges that place in the top 90% of their categories display their individual ranks. Those not in the top

90%, i.e., the bottom 10% of the rankings, instead display the bottom decile ranking ranges within their specific ranking categories and are listed alphabetically.

You cannot compare the ranks of institutions in different categories because schools are compared only with their ranking category peers. But you can compare all the statistical data supplied by the schools across all U.S. News ranking categories. For example, you can use statistical data such as tuition and test scores to see how a big research university stacks up against a small liberal arts college.

Schools that did not meet certain criteria that U.S. News requires to be numerically ranked are listed as unranked. That group includes specialty schools that focus on business, engineering and technology, art, faith, health, medical, special focus, research, tribal, and other miscellaneous schools without a category, as well as international schools.

In addition, schools that are very small and schools that don't have a six-year bachelor's degree graduation rate are not ranked and instead are listed as unranked.

Additional Information for International Students

Across various sections, U.S. News incorporates information specific to [international students](#). For example, there's information on how many undergraduates come from other countries, how many countries were represented during the 2023-2024 academic year and special services for international students. Students can also find answers to questions such as: What are the application deadlines for international students? Is a preapplication form required?

International students may have to demonstrate proficiency in English by submitting scores on the Test of English as a Foreign Language or the International English Language Testing System; if so, what is the minimum TOEFL paper test, TOEFL internet-based test and/or IELTS score required? What were the most recent average TOEFL and IELTS scores? Can the TOEFL be submitted in place of the SAT or ACT?

U.S. News also provides financial information specific to international students. Are advance deposits required of international applicants in addition to the tuition deposits required of all students?

Which types of aid are offered to international students? How many international undergraduates received such aid during the 2023-2024 academic year? You can find everything you need to know about which forms to file and when to file them.

Best Colleges Frequently Asked Questions for Media

Find answers to common questions about the U.S. News Best Colleges rankings.

1. How do you correctly write the company's name?

It is U.S. News & World Report. On subsequent references, the company is often called U.S. News.

2. Does U.S. News still publish magazines?

No. Today, U.S. News is a multifaceted digital media company dedicated to helping consumers, business leaders and policy officials make important decisions in their lives. The last print issue of the magazine was published in December 2010. U.S. News does publish an annual [print guidebook](#) for its rankings of colleges plus a separate annual guidebook for its rankings of hospitals.

3. I have questions about the rankings, the data used in the rankings or the methodologies. Whom should I contact?

Visit the [About the U.S. News Education Rankings Methodologies](#) page for detailed methodologies and frequently asked questions about our rankings. For other questions about Best Colleges rankings data and methodologies, email education-pr@usnews.com. Please specify which ranking(s) you are interested in.

4. I am a member of the news media. How can I get my name added to your email lists for breaking news and information about your rankings and web launches?

Email education-pr@usnews.com.

5. How do I reach a U.S. News staff member for comment?

Email education-pr@usnews.com.

Campus Ethnic Diversity Methodology

Students at schools that place high on these lists are most likely to encounter undergraduates from different racial or ethnic groups.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

College-bound students who prioritize studying with people of different racial and ethnic backgrounds will want to consider [campus ethnic diversity](#) when choosing a school.

To identify colleges where students are most likely to encounter undergraduates from racial or ethnic groups different from their own, U.S. News & World Report factored in the total proportion of minority students and the overall mix of groups. This index measures the probability that any two people chosen at random from a given school are of different races or ethnic groups.

International students were not counted because colleges do not report each student's ethnicity separately; they only report that those students are not from the U.S. Enrollment and ethnicity data was drawn from each institution's fall 2023 total undergraduate degree-seeking full- and part-time student body as reported to U.S. News. If the school did not report 2023 enrollment data to U.S. News, then diversity index data based on fall 2022 data from the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) Data Center was used.

The ethnic categories used in the calculations are: non-Hispanic African-American, Hispanic, American Indian, Pacific Islander/Native Hawaiian, Asian, non-Hispanic white and multiracial (two or more races). For the purpose of this calculation, U.S. News classified students who did not identify themselves as members of any of these demographic groups as whites who are non-Hispanic.

The U.S. News formula produced a diversity index that ranges from 0 to 1. The closer a school's diversity index number is to 1, the more diverse the student population is. In other words, the closer the number is to 1, the more likely that students will attend classes with peers from a wider array of ethnic groups. Conversely, the further away from 1 a school's diversity index is, the more ethnically homogenous students attending those classes are likely to be.

Schools whose enrollment is made up of mostly one ethnic group will not score highly using this ethnic diversity index measure because students are unlikely to encounter peers from a variety of other ethnic backgrounds on campus. For example, [historically Black colleges](#) and universities tend to score very low on this measure since their student bodies are made up of predominantly one ethnic group.

Philip Meyer and Shawn McIntosh created the basis for this methodology, which was referenced in [the article](#) "The USA Today Index of Ethnic Diversity," published in 1992 in the International Journal of Public Opinion Research.

Each school's profile page on [usnews.com](#) publishes detailed information on the student body, including ethnicity data. There is also data on the ethnic backgrounds of instructional faculty.

How U.S. News Collects Best Colleges Rankings Data

Find out the sources used to compile our Best Colleges survey questions

By Robert Morse and Kenneth Hines

U.S. News & World Report strongly believes in the transparency of the data collection and ranking process. Here's a look at the annual data collection process that U.S. News uses to collect data for the Best Colleges rankings.

About U.S. News' statistical surveys

U.S. News surveyed schools for the 2025 Best Colleges rankings in the spring and summer of 2024. There were two surveys: a main survey that collected general information and a financial aid survey that collected information specific to expenses and discounts. The former annual finance survey, which had collected data on school expenditures, was discontinued. Last year for all schools, U.S. News transitioned to using expenditures data sourced directly from the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) Data Center for the financial resources ranking indicator, making surveying schools directly unnecessary.

The two remaining surveys used an online, password-protected data collection system. U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data. However, the data collection process has data validation built into the surveys to alert schools that the data they are entering may be incorrect. For example, schools were alerted when values they reported conflicted with input from a related question, reflected a large change from what they reported the previous year, or simply did not add up correctly.

After schools entered their data and completed the automated assessment process, U.S. News asked each school to have a top official sign an electronic data verification form stating that its data is accurate. The few schools that didn't have a senior official sign their U.S. News main statistical survey have this footnote on their profile on usnews.com: "School declined to have a school official verify the accuracy of the information contained in the U.S. News main statistical survey."

After the data is submitted, analysts at U.S. News review schools' submissions to detect outliers, comparing schools' data for that indicator with other data from that school's peer institutions and some third-party sources. Schools with flagged data were asked in July 2024 to confirm or revise their figures to be published and incorporated into the rankings. Schools that failed to confirm the accuracy of their data upon follow-up communications may have had their data deleted.

A new step starting with this edition was a data review that took place in August 2024. U.S. News emailed each eligible schools' statistical survey contacts its draft rankings along with the corresponding survey data used to compute them. Schools had two weeks to carefully review the data and respond with any corrections. Schools were not provided the draft rankings of any other institutions. They were not provided any data to review besides survey information their institution reported in the most recent U.S. News surveys. They were also informed their draft rankings may change by publication.

The data reported for the first time in these surveys was the only U.S. News statistical survey data used in the rankings computations for the 2025 edition. Data schools reported on older cohorts in previous years' surveys was in some cases displayed for reference but was never used in the calculations.

About the Common Data Set for U.S. News surveys

U.S. News uses almost all the questions from the Common Data Set (CDS) as part of the survey. The CDS is a set of standards and definitions for higher education data that is collected by publishers and used in higher education research. The CDS is not a survey, and there isn't a central database that holds each school's CDS.

The CDS is a collaborative effort between publishers and higher education officials that has improved the quality and accuracy of information that colleges provide and make available to consumers. U.S. News is one of three publishers that manage the CDS initiative.

To reduce survey burden, many schools provided completed forms with CDS data that U.S. News entered into the schools' statistical surveys on their behalf. U.S. News has informed schools that the 2025 edition of the Best Colleges rankings will be the last year for this manual data entry approach. For future editions, U.S. News will require schools to provide their CDS data to U.S. News via form-fillable PDFs accessible from the CDS website. The data will be programmatically loaded into schools' U.S. News surveys, expediting the survey completion process and minimizing back-and-forth with survey respondents.

It's important to note that all three participating publishers (listed below) ask many additional questions of colleges beyond what is covered in the CDS. Responses to these additional questions are used on each publisher's website and in print and other products.

In the case of U.S. News, some of the additional data requested in the annual Best Colleges statistical surveys – such as faculty salaries – is used as indicators in the ranking methodology to compute the rankings. Most of the questions U.S. News asks that are not part of the CDS appear on usnews.com as part of each college's profile but are not part of the ranking methodology.

You can download the 2024-2025 CDS through the [initiative's website](#). Stay up to date on the initiative via its website, where the most current CDS is posted, along with information on activities related to the CDS and contact information for members of the CDS publishers' team. Publishers participating in the initiative are:

- The College Board
- Peterson's
- U.S. News

You can participate in the CDS initiative by joining the [CDS Google discussion group](#) hosted by the College Board, which can be accessed from the CDS initiative's website.

About data sourced externally from U.S. News surveys

For some ranking factors and school profile information, U.S. News also makes use of data sourced directly from IPEDS, [the College Scorecard](#) and via its relationship with [Elsevier](#). For schools that declined to report any data to U.S. News, the quantitative data used in their rankings was sourced entirely from these third-party sources.

For IPEDS data, U.S. News used the most recent version of IPEDS data available. For all applicable indicators, this meant the provisional release data was used. But the final release data was used for older cohorts in the four-year averages of graduation and retention rates.

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Best Undergraduate Business Programs Methodology

These rankings are based on surveys of deans and senior faculty members at business programs.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report's [Best Undergraduate Business Programs rankings](#) are based solely on the judgments of deans and senior faculty members at peer institutions who participated in a peer assessment survey.

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News surveyed deans and senior faculty members at each of the 532 undergraduate business programs accredited by [AACSB International](#). All 532 programs were ranked.

These deans and faculty members – two at each AACSB-accredited business program – were asked to rate the quality of all programs with which they were familiar on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). Individuals who were unfamiliar with a particular school's programs were asked to select "don't know."

U.S. News determined average peer assessment scores for each business program by computing a trimmed mean – eliminating the two highest and two lowest scores given by respondents. Average scores were then sorted and undergraduate business programs were ranked in descending order based on the average peer assessment score.

Schools in the overall undergraduate business school rankings with average peer assessment scores of less than 2.0 are listed in alphabetical order in a ranking range based on the number of programs that also scored below 2.0. U.S. News will supply schools or programs that are listed in the ranking range with their numerical rankings if a school official submits a request to official@usnews.com.

In 2024, the business survey had a 46.9% response rate. The overall undergraduate business programs ranking was based only on these 2024 survey results.

Specialty Rankings

U.S. News also asked those same peer assessment survey respondents to nominate up to 15 of the best programs in these 13 business specialty areas:

- Accounting
- Business analytics
- Entrepreneurship
- Finance
- Insurance / risk management
- International business
- Management

- Management information systems
- Marketing
- Production / operations management
- Quantitative analysis / methods
- Real estate
- Supply chain management / logistics

Undergraduate programs that received the most mentions in each area are ranked in descending order by number of mentions.

A school or program had to receive seven or more nominations in a specific specialty area to be listed. This means that schools ranked at the bottom of each specialty ranking received at least seven nominations.

Rankings of the best undergraduate business programs in a specialty area are based solely on the peer assessment survey conducted in spring and summer 2024. Schools offering any courses in a specialty are eligible to be ranked in that specialty. Schools did not need to have a listed program or a specific undergraduate major in a specialty area to be ranked in that specialty area.

Best Undergraduate Engineering Programs Methodology

These rankings are based on surveys of deans and senior faculty members at engineering programs.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report's Best Undergraduate Engineering Programs rankings are based solely on the judgments of deans and senior faculty at peer institutions who participated in a peer assessment survey.

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News surveyed deans and faculty members of undergraduate engineering programs accredited by [ABET](#), the Accreditation Board for Engineering and Technology. Respondents were asked to rate each program they were familiar with on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). Individuals who were unfamiliar with a particular school's programs were asked to select "don't know." Each qualifying engineering school or program was sent two peer assessment surveys.

U.S. News has separate rankings for the 209 undergraduate engineering programs at colleges or universities that [offer doctoral degrees in engineering](#) and for the 286 undergraduate engineering programs at institutions where the terminal degree in engineering is a [bachelor's or master's](#). There were two separate surveys and respondent groups, which means that deans and senior faculty only rated engineering programs within their institution's ranking category. All programs on both surveys were ranked.

Research at the graduate level often influences the undergraduate curriculum, and engineering schools with doctoral programs in engineering tend to have the widest possible range of undergraduate engineering courses and program offerings. Students who prefer a program focused on undergraduate studies can consult the list of top programs at schools where the terminal engineering degree is a bachelor's or master's. This approach of having two separate engineering ranking categories, which U.S. News has used for many years, was based on recommendations from the American Society for Engineering Education.

Average peer assessment scores for each engineering program were determined by computing a trimmed mean – eliminating the two highest and two lowest scores given by respondents. Average scores were then sorted and undergraduate engineering programs were ranked in descending order based on the average peer assessment score.

In the overall undergraduate engineering rankings in each of the two categories, schools with average peer assessment scores of less than 2.0 are listed in alphabetical order in a ranking range based on the number of programs that also earned scores below 2.0. U.S. News will supply schools or programs that are listed in the ranking range with their numerical rankings if a school official submits a request to official@usnews.com.

Of those surveyed in 2024, the group whose terminal degree in engineering is a bachelor's or master's had a 40.8% response rate, and the doctoral group's response rate was 55.9%.

The overall ranking in both engineering categories was based only on the 2024 survey results.

Specialty Rankings

U.S. News also asked the same peer assessment survey respondents for nominations of up to 15 of the best engineering programs in 12 specialty engineering areas:

- Aerospace / aeronautical / astronautical
- Bioengineering / biomedical
- Biological and agricultural
- Chemical
- Civil
- Computer engineering
- Electrical / electronic / communications
- Environmental / environmental health
- Industrial / manufacturing / systems
- Materials
- Mechanical
- Petroleum

Schools that received the most mentions in each specialty appear on the site ranked in descending order by number of mentions.

A school or program had to receive seven or more nominations in a specialty area to be listed. This means that schools ranked at the bottom of each specialty ranking received at least seven nominations.

Fewer specialty areas are ranked in the engineering programs at colleges where the terminal degree in engineering is a bachelor's or master's, since many specialty areas had fewer than five schools that received seven or more ratings. For U.S. News to publish a specialty engineering ranking, five or more programs in that area had to receive seven or more ratings in the most recent year.

The rankings of the best engineering programs in a specialty are based solely on the results from the spring and summer 2024 peer survey. Schools offering any courses in a specialty are eligible to be ranked in that specialty area. Specialty rankings are not based on whether an engineering program has specific undergraduate-level ABET accreditation in that specialty area.

Best Nursing Schools Methodology

See how U.S. News ranks the Best Nursing Schools for undergrads.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report's undergraduate [Bachelor of Science in Nursing \(BSN\) rankings](#) are based solely on the judgments of deans and senior faculty members of nursing schools and departments at institutions around the country who participated in a peer assessment survey.

To have received the survey and been ranked, an institution's nursing school or department that offers the BSN degree must have met both of these criteria:

1. Be accredited at the bachelor's level by either the Commission on Collegiate Nursing Education or the Accreditation Commission for Education in Nursing.
2. Be a regionally accredited institution that awarded at least 50 BSN degrees, according to 2021-2022 data from the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) Data Center.

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News surveyed deans and senior faculty members at each of the 686 undergraduate BSN degree-granting nursing programs that met the above criteria. All 686 were ranked.

These deans and faculty members were asked to rate the academic quality of peer institutions' BSN programs on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). Individuals who were unfamiliar with a particular school's programs were asked to select "don't know."

Average peer assessment scores for each nursing program were determined by computing a trimmed mean – eliminating the two highest and two lowest scores given by respondents. Average scores were then sorted and BSN programs were ranked in descending order based on the average peer assessment score. Of those surveyed, 32% responded.

In the overall BSN ranking, programs with average peer assessment scores of less than 2.0 are listed in alphabetical order in a ranking range based on the number of programs that also earned scores below 2.0. U.S. News will supply schools or programs that are listed in the ranking range with their numerical rankings if a school official submits a request to official@usnews.com.

A-Plus Schools for B Students Methodology

To determine these schools, we looked at admissions data and average first-year student retention rates.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

To judge the level of quality at each institution on the [A-Plus Schools for B Students](#) list, U.S. News & World Report first examined two variables: the school's performance in the 2025 edition of the [Best Colleges](#) rankings and the average first-year student retention rate.

Since the U.S. News rankings are a gauge of excellence, schools in [National Universities](#), [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#), [Regional Universities](#) and [Regional Colleges](#) all had to first be ranked in the top 90% of their 2025 Best Colleges ranking categories to be eligible for the A-Plus Schools for B Students list.

The average first-year student retention rate – the percentage of first-time first-year students who returned for their second year the following fall – was also calculated for first-year classes entering between fall 2019 and fall 2022. Schools that made the first cut had to bring an average of at least 75% of their first-year students back the next fall.

In addition to passing the first two screens, to make the final list of the A-Plus Schools for B Students, colleges had to admit a meaningful proportion of students who didn't get straight A's in high school. U.S. News determined this by using fall 2023 admissions data, including high school class standing, scores on the mathematics and evidence-based reading and writing portions of the SAT, or composite ACT scores.

Whether the SAT or ACT was used in making this list's calculations depended on which score was submitted by the largest proportion of students who applied and then enrolled in the fall 2023 entering class for each school. In some cases, fall 2022 data was used when fall 2023 was reported on less than half of the incoming class and fall 2022 data had been reported on at least half of the incoming class. Test scores still needed to be within the ranges noted below to make the list.

The specific screening criteria noted below, which apply to all schools in all ranking categories unless stated otherwise, were used to create the 2025 A-Plus Schools for B Students list, featuring around 105 schools. Admissions data was from the fall 2023 entering class.

- To appear on the A-Plus Schools for B Students list, colleges had to:
- Be ranked in the top 90% of the overall 2025 Best Colleges rankings in their categories
- Have an SAT 75th percentile score less than or equal to 1,350 and an SAT 25th percentile score greater than or equal to 980, based on evidence-based reading and writing portions and math; or have an ACT composite 75th percentile score less than or equal to 30 and an ACT composite 25th percentile score greater than or equal to 20
- Have no more than 50% of their first-year students place in the top 10% of their high school class (for National Universities and National Liberal Arts Colleges only)
- Have no more than 80% of their first-year students place in the top 25% of their high school class

- Have at least 40% of their first-year students place in the top 25% of their high school class
- Have an average first-year student retention rate of 75% or higher

Data sources used to determine the A-Plus Schools for B Students list are described in the [main methodology](#). U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data.

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Best Computer Science Programs Methodology

These rankings are based on surveys of deans and senior faculty at schools with computer science programs.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report's [Best Undergraduate Computer Science Programs](#) rankings are based solely on the judgments of deans and senior faculty members of computer science departments at institutions around the country who participated in a peer assessment survey.

To have received the survey and been ranked, an institution's computer science department must have met at least one of these two criteria:

- House a computer science bachelor's degree program accredited by [ABET](#), the Accreditation Board for Engineering and Technology.
- Be a regionally accredited institution that awarded at least 20 bachelor's degrees in computer science in 2021-2022, according to the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) Data Center.

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News surveyed deans and senior faculty members at each of the 584 undergraduate computer science programs that met at least one of the criteria above. All programs surveyed were ranked.

These deans and faculty members were asked to rate the academic quality of peer institutions' computer science programs on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). Individuals who were unfamiliar with a particular school's programs were asked to select "don't know."

Average peer assessment scores for each computer science program were determined by computing a trimmed mean – eliminating the two highest and two lowest scores given by respondents. Average scores were then sorted and computer science programs were ranked in descending order. Of those surveyed, 24.8% responded.

In the overall computer science ranking, programs with average peer assessment scores of less than 2.0 are listed in alphabetical order in a ranking range based on the number of programs that also earned scores below 2.0. U.S. News will supply schools or programs that are listed in the ranking range with their numerical rankings if a school official submits a request to official@usnews.com.

Specialty Rankings

U.S. News also asked those same peer assessment survey respondents to nominate up to 15 of the best programs in the 10 computer science specialty areas listed below. Specialty rankings are based solely on nominations by survey respondents.

- Artificial intelligence

- Biocomputing / bioinformatics / biotechnology
- Computer systems
- Cybersecurity
- Data analytics / science
- Game / simulation development
- Mobile / web applications
- Programming languages
- Software engineering
- Theory

The 10 computer science specialty areas are ranked in descending order based on the number of mentions they received. A program needed seven or more nominations in a specialty area to be ranked. This means that schools ranked at the bottom of each specialty ranking received at least seven nominations.

Schools offering any courses in a specialty are eligible to be ranked in that specialty. Schools did not need a listed program or major in a specialty area to qualify.

Programs That Enhance Student Experience

These programs expose college students to new academic experiences.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report ranked programs at universities and colleges that offer well-regarded study abroad, service learning and other special programs that, research shows, are linked to student success and positive learning outcomes. We identified eight such programs with the help of education experts, including staff members of the American Association of Colleges and Universities.

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News asked top academics to name the schools with the best programs in eight areas:

- [First-Year Experiences](#)
- [Co-ops/Internships](#)
- [Learning Communities](#)
- [Senior Capstone](#)
- [Service Learning](#)
- [Study Abroad](#)
- [Undergraduate Research/Creative Projects](#)
- [Writing in the Disciplines](#)

College presidents, provosts and admissions deans who participated in the annual U.S. News peer assessment survey in 2024 were asked to nominate up to 15 standout schools in each of the eight program types. Any institution in the [Best Colleges](#) rankings was eligible for these rankings, regardless of its Best Colleges ranking category.

Rankings of these eight programs that enhance educational outcomes are based solely on the responses to this separate section of the 2024 peer assessment survey.

These rankings focus on offerings that can enhance a student's college experience but aren't always directly measured in a college's regular peer assessment survey results or its overall rank.

The rankings are solely based on the total number of nominations each school received in one of the eight specific programs. Schools with the most nominations rank the highest in that particular program, and the rest are sorted in descending order based on their total number of nominations. Schools must have received 10 or more nominations in a particular program to be ranked. That means that schools at the bottom of each ranking received at least 10 nominations in that specific program offering.

The rankings are solely based on the total number of nominations each school received in one of the eight specific programs. Schools with the most nominations rank the highest in that particular program,

and the rest are sorted in descending order based on their total number of nominations. Schools must receive 10 or more nominations in a particular program to be ranked.

Embargoed – Subject to Change

Best Psychology Programs Methodology

These rankings are based on surveys of department chairs and senior faculty at undergraduate psychology programs.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report's ranking of medium to large [undergraduate psychology programs](#) is based solely on the judgments of department chairs and senior faculty members at psychology departments from institutions around the country who participated in a peer assessment survey.

To have received the survey and been ranked, an institution's undergraduate psychology department must be a regionally accredited institution that awarded a medium to large number of bachelor's degrees in psychology, according to 2021-2022 completions data from the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#).

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News surveyed department chairs and senior faculty members at 697 undergraduate psychology departments that met the criteria above.

These department chairs and faculty members were asked to rate the academic quality of peer institutions' undergraduate psychology programs on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). Individuals who were unfamiliar with a particular school's programs were asked to select "don't know."

Average peer assessment scores for each psychology program were determined by computing a trimmed mean – eliminating the two highest and two lowest scores given by respondents. Average scores were then sorted and psychology programs were ranked in descending order based on the average peer assessment scores. Of those surveyed, 19.5% responded.

To be numerically ranked with a published average peer score, a program needed to receive 10 rankings after computing the trimmed mean. Of those surveyed, 681 psychology programs received enough ratings and were ranked.

In the overall ranking, psychology programs with average peer assessment scores of less than 2.0 are listed in alphabetical order in a ranking range based on the number of programs that also earned scores below 2.0. U.S. News will supply schools or programs that are listed in the ranking range with their numerical rankings if a school official submits a request to official@usnews.com.

Best Economics Programs Methodology

These rankings are based on surveys of department chairs and faculty at economics programs.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report's ranking of medium to large [undergraduate economics programs](#) is based solely on the judgments of department chairs and senior faculty members in economics departments at institutions around the country who participated in a peer assessment survey.

To have received the survey and been ranked, an institution's economics department must be a regionally accredited institution that awarded a medium to large number of bachelor's degrees in economics, according to 2021-2022 completions data from the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) Data Center.

These are the undergraduate economics fields that were included: economics, agricultural economics, natural resource economics, pharmacoeconomics/pharmaceutical economics, and business/managerial economics.

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News surveyed department chairs and senior faculty members at each of the 318 undergraduate economics programs that met the criteria above. All programs surveyed were ranked.

These department chairs and faculty members were asked to rate the academic quality of peer institutions' economics programs on a 5-point scale: outstanding (5), strong (4), good (3), adequate (2) or marginal (1). Individuals who were unfamiliar with a particular school's programs were asked to select "don't know."

Average peer assessment scores for each economics program were determined by computing a trimmed mean – eliminating the two highest and two lowest scores given by respondents. Average scores were then sorted and economics programs were ranked in descending order based on the average peer assessment scores. Of those surveyed, 35.2% responded.

In the overall undergraduate economics ranking, programs with average peer assessment scores of less than 2.0 are listed in alphabetical order in a ranking range based on the number of programs that also scored below 2.0. U.S. News will supply schools or programs that are listed in the ranking range with their numerical rankings if a school official submits a request to official@usnews.com.

Best Colleges for Veterans Methodology

Learn how U.S. News ranks colleges with benefits for veterans and active-duty service members.

By Eric Brooks and Robert Morse

U.S. News & World Report's 2025 [Best Colleges for Veterans](#) rankings provide data on top-ranked schools that make pursuing a college education more affordable for veterans and active-duty service members. As part of U.S. News' annual statistical survey of undergraduate schools conducted in the spring and summer of 2024, schools reported their enrollment of, and benefits for, veterans and active-duty service members.

Schools are only included in the 2025 edition of the Best Colleges for Veterans ranking if they meet the following criteria, as reported to U.S. News during the spring and summer 2024 statistical survey data collection:

- The institution is certified for the GI Bill.
- The institution participates in the Yellow Ribbon Program or is a public school.

To be eligible to be ranked, the institution must have enrolled a minimum of 20 full-time and part-time undergraduate veterans and active-duty service members in the 2023-2024 academic year, as reported to U.S. News during the spring and summer 2024 statistical survey data collection. In addition, the institution must be ranked in the top half of one of the 2025 Best Colleges ranking categories: [National Universities](#), [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#), [Regional Colleges](#) or [Regional Universities](#). The two regional categories are each further divided into North, South, Midwest and West regions.

Schools that qualify for the Best Colleges for Veterans lists are ranked to a significant degree based on their overall score in the 2025 Best Colleges rankings. Schools receive extra credit if they are public schools, or private schools that make Yellow Ribbon benefits available to all qualifying students, or provide the maximum Yellow Ribbon funding.

This approach allows schools to receive additional credit in the Best Colleges for Veterans rankings if they make the Yellow Ribbon program fully available to students. The order of schools in the Best Colleges for Veterans rankings may differ modestly from where they place in the overall Best Colleges rankings.

Data sources used in the Best Colleges for Veterans rankings are described in the main methodology. U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data.

For a detailed explanation of the overall Best Colleges rankings, see the [methodology](#).

Most Innovative Schools Methodology

These schools are making promising innovations in technology, curriculum and other areas.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

U.S. News & World Report asked top academics participating in a peer assessment survey to name the institutions they think are the [most innovative schools](#) for the 2025 Best Colleges rankings. The survey was conducted in the spring and summer of 2024.

College presidents, provosts and admissions deans were asked to nominate up to 15 colleges or universities in their U.S. News [Best Colleges](#) ranking category that are making the most innovative improvements in terms of curriculum, faculty, students, campus life, technology or facilities.

The Most Innovative Schools rankings are based solely on the top academics' responses to this question, which was a separate section of U.S. News' annual peer assessment survey in 2024.

These rankings enable top college officials to spotlight schools that are making cutting-edge developments on their campuses. Some institutions that made the Most Innovative Schools lists may not place highly in the overall rankings or score at the top of the regular peer assessment survey.

The lists, organized by U.S. News ranking categories, contain the schools from the 2024 survey that received the most nominations. They are ranked in descending order based on the number of top-15 nominations they received. A school must have received seven or more nominations to be ranked as one of the most innovative in its U.S. News ranking category.

Best Value Schools Methodology

U.S. News considers four variables in determining the schools that offer the best value.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

Affordability matters in finding the best fit school. But for many prospective students, a school's sticker price alone does not capture the true cost of attending. To determine which public, private and for-profit colleges and universities offer the best value for students, U.S. News & World Report factors academic quality and cost after accounting for total expenses and financial aid.

The 2025 [Best Value Schools rankings](#) are based on four ranking indicators. These indicators are:

- Academic quality (overall score in the 2025 Best Colleges rankings) relative to the average discount price paid by 2023-2024 full-time undergraduates after receiving need-based scholarships or grants. This indicator is weighted 50%.
- The percentage of all full-time 2023-2024 academic year undergraduates receiving need-based scholarships or grants (20% weight).
- Among 2023-2024 academic year full-time undergraduates who received need-based aid, the percentage of that percentage who received a grant or scholarship – aid that students don't have to pay back (20% weight). This matters because even schools generous with aid may provide significant shares of it as need-based loans or work study, both of which are less beneficial to students than aid primarily in scholarship or grant forms.
- The average discount from the school's total 2023-2024 sticker price for 2023-2024 full-time undergraduates receiving the average need-based grant (10% weight).

Among each of the above Best Value Schools ranking indicators, schools' scores were only compared with other schools in their U.S. News overall ranking category to ensure valid comparisons. Specifically, there are 10 distinct Best Value Schools rankings that group similarly structured schools together for valid comparisons. This placement is mapped to [Carnegie Classifications](#). The 10 rankings were the following: [National Universities](#) and [National Liberal Arts Colleges](#); plus [Regional Colleges](#) and [Regional Universities](#), which are each split into North, South, Midwest and West regions.

Within each ranking, schools' individual ranks were calculated by standardizing the scores eligible schools achieved across indicators, then weighing and summing those standardized scores. For example, whichever National University garnered the highest total weighted score was No. 1 in the Best Value Schools National Universities ranking. Remaining schools are numerically ranked by category in descending order of their cumulative weighted scores.

To be eligible for inclusion in the Best Value Schools ranking, colleges and universities first had to report sufficient 2023-2024 academic year need-based financial aid data to U.S. News in spring and summer 2024. Those that did not report on-campus food and housing were excluded from the rankings, as were any that did not charge tuition, such as the U.S. military academies, which are free. Also, schools needed to be

ranked in the top half of their U.S. News overall 2025 Best Colleges ranking category to ensure they were strong academically.

For public institutions, each ranking indicator used 2023-2024 out-of-state tuition and the percentage of out-of-state students receiving need-based scholarships or grants. U.S. News does this because the Best Value Schools rankings are designed for comparing colleges across state lines. Of course, students who attend public colleges in-state typically pay less tuition, i.e., "in-state," than their out-of-state peers, and for them the public universities in their own state may be of especially great value.

Likewise, the statistics used to measure affordability use percentages and averages, but the final amount any student pays will vary based on school policy and individual circumstances. With that in mind, the Best Value Schools rankings are a starting point for exploration rather than the last word on which school will offer any one person the best return on investment.

Data sources used in the Best Value Schools rankings are described in the [main methodology](#). U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data.

Below are more detailed descriptions of the four ranking indicators used in the Best Value Schools rankings.

1. Ratio of quality to price: A school's overall score in the 2025 Best Colleges rankings was divided by the net cost for the 2023-2024 academic year for a full-time undergraduate receiving the average need-based financial aid award in scholarships or grants.

The higher the ratio of a school's 2025 Best Colleges overall score (0-100 scale) to the discounted total cost for the academic year (after subtracting the average 2023-2024 academic year need-based scholarship or grant aid), the better the value.

Total cost equals the sum of these costs for each school in the 2023-2024 academic year: tuition, food and housing, fees, and other expenses, including transportation and books. For schools that didn't break out these items separately, U.S. News used their comprehensive fee for tuition and food and housing.

2. Need-based aid: Another factor is the percentage of all full-time undergraduates receiving need-based scholarships or grants during the 2023-2024 academic year. The higher the percentage, the better the school scores on this indicator.

3. Percent of need-based aid recipients awarded scholarship or grants: Among the percent of full-time undergraduates receiving need-based aid, this is the percent of those receiving a need-based grant or scholarship. This was calculated by dividing the percentage of 2023-2024 full-time undergraduates receiving need-based grants or scholarships in the 2023-2024 academic year by the percentage receiving any need-based aid during that same year that included, but was not limited to, grants or scholarships and need-based loans or work study. A school must have awarded need-based aid to at least 10% of its full-time undergraduates to be scored on this ranking factor. The higher the percentage receiving scholarships or grants, the better the school scores on this indicator.

4. Average discount: This is the percentage of a school's 2023-2024 total sticker cost, which is the sum of tuition, food and housing, fees, transportation, books, and other expenses, that was covered by the average 2023-2024 need-based scholarship or grant award for full-time undergraduates in the same academic year. The higher the discount percentage, the better the school scores on this indicator.

Embargoed – Subject to Change

Best Undergraduate Teaching Rankings Methodology

These rankings highlight schools that emphasize providing high-quality instruction to undergrads.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

In the spring and summer of 2024, U.S. News & World Report asked top academics to name the schools they believe have faculty with a remarkably strong commitment to undergraduate teaching.

The rankings for [Best Undergraduate Teaching](#), as part of the 2025 Best Colleges rankings, focus on schools whose faculty and administrators are committed to teaching undergraduate students in a high-quality manner. College presidents, provosts and admissions deans who participated in the annual U.S. News peer assessment survey were asked to nominate up to 15 schools in their [Best Colleges](#) ranking category that have strength in undergraduate teaching.

The Best Undergraduate Teaching rankings are based solely on the responses to this separate section of the 2024 peer assessment survey.

These rankings focus on a very important part of the undergraduate academic experience that is not always directly measured in a college's regular peer assessment survey results or in its overall rank.

The lists, organized by U.S. News ranking categories, include the colleges that received the most nominations. They are ranked in descending order based on the number of nominations they received. Schools had to receive seven or more nominations to be ranked.

FAQ: 2025 Best Value Schools Rankings

Find answers to common questions regarding financial aid and the Best Value Schools.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

1. What are "Best Value Schools"?

These are schools that are above average academically and cost considerably less than many other schools when the financial aid that they dispense in the form of need-based grants and [scholarships](#) is taken into account.

2. How are the Best Value Schools rankings determined?

The Best Value Schools rankings are computed using four variables:

- The percentage of all undergraduates receiving need-based scholarships or grants
- The average discount from each school's total sticker price, which is the total of tuition, food and housing, fees, transportation, books, and other expenses, in relation to the average need-based grant at that school
- The ratio of the quality, which is determined by a school's overall score in the 2025 Best Colleges rankings, to what a student would pay after receiving the school's average need-based scholarship or grant package
- Among the percent of students receiving need-based aid, the percent receiving a scholarship or grant

To be eligible for the Best Value Schools rankings, U.S. News considers only institutions in the top half of their 2025 Best Colleges ranking categories that have supplied the data needed to compute all four ranking variables described above on the U.S. News financial aid statistical survey conducted in spring and summer 2024 for the 2023-2024 academic year.

Data sources used in the Best Value Schools rankings are described in the [main methodology](#). U.S. News relies on schools to accurately report their data.

See more details about the [methodology for the Best Value Schools](#).

3. What does "discount price" mean?

This is the average amount students and their families actually paid after receiving scholarships or grants based on financial need in the 2023-2024 academic year. Scholarships or grants are the money that is free to the student and family. That means need-based loans and work-study are not considered part of the average need-based grant, since they are not free to the student, and they aren't part of the average discount price calculation.

4. Why does U.S. News base the Best Value Schools rankings on out-of-state tuition for public colleges?

The rankings assume that many students attain the best value for them by attending a top public college in their own state, where they are eligible for what is typically far lower in-state tuition based on their residency in that specific state.

The Best Value Schools rankings are intended for comparing schools across state lines; therefore, U.S. News uses out-of-state tuition and the related need-based financial aid scholarships and grants that go to out-of-state students to compare public colleges with private colleges.

5. Where does a school's 2023-2024 academic year tuition, food and housing, expenses, and other need-based financial aid data used in the Best Value Schools rankings come from?

Each school supplied the data to U.S. News in the spring and summer of 2024 on the U.S. News financial aid survey. In a few cases, U.S. News obtained 2023-2024 tuition, food and housing, and other expenses, including books and travel, from the U.S. Department of Education's [College Navigator](#) website.

6. How can I negotiate a better financial aid package?

Many schools are willing to reconsider their first offer, especially for a student they really want. Most say they reconsider only if presented with new information, so you will want to contact the financial aid office if you can demonstrate ways your financial situation has meaningfully changed since filling out the financial aid forms.

Your family's financial situation may have changed significantly due to a variety of reasons, including a parent losing their job or a grandparent needing medical care.

A more direct approach is to ask one school to meet or beat another school's offer. Some schools invite students to notify them if they receive better financial aid packages from other schools.

Whatever their rationale for seeking increased aid, families should avoid using the word "negotiate" in their discussions. The term irks many college aid officers – even though aid officers negotiate regularly, the term directly contradicts their ability to assert that they don't.

7. What is the best way to find out about scholarships?

The [U.S. News Scholarship Finder](#) can assist your search for scholarships and other financial aid options. You can narrow your search by stats like test scores, location, type of award and school type. U.S. News has advice on securing money for college as well as answers to [frequently asked questions about scholarships](#) and where to find them.

In addition, there are dozens of resources online devoted to scholarships, such as your high school's or a community foundation's website. You can find national scholarships on database websites including Fastweb, Cappex, Scholarship America and Unigo. With a little digging, you can uncover information that can help you pay for school.

Frequently Asked Questions: U.S. News My Fit

Find out how the U.S. News My Fit tool can help you identify college matches.

1. What is the U.S. News My Fit tool?

U.S. News My Fit is a custom ranking tool that U.S. News developed to help students and parents find [colleges and universities](#) that fit their needs based on qualities they care about. Parents and students can enter up to 23 different factors, and U.S. News will rank the schools based on their preferences.

The U.S. News My Fit custom ranking runs those preferences through our proprietary algorithm using the U.S. News database of more than 1,800 schools and then returns a list of schools for consideration.

2. Can I demo the My Fit tool?

Yes, [you can demo the My Fit tool](#), which lets you explore some of the available criteria and see the number of schools that fit you. [Subscribing to U.S. News College Compass](#) will allow you to see the schools.

3. How do I access U.S. News My Fit?

To begin, sign into the [U.S. News College Compass](#) or [sign up for an account](#) if you are not yet a subscriber. In addition to the My Fit tool, College Compass gives you access to expanded profiles for more than 1,800 schools, financial aid information and much more.

4. How do I use U.S. News My Fit?

To get started, simply begin entering some basic facts about you or your child. To run a basic search, the tool must have the student's high school GPA, or SAT or ACT composite test scores.

After that, you can add as many or as few other school factors as you wish. For each factor, you can also select a level of importance, from "Not Important" to "Required." To change these levels of importance, use the star ratings below each factor.

5. I am not seeing a school that I want to research in my results. Why not?

The U.S. News My Fit tool relies on the U.S. News proprietary database of college data. There are some instances where individual schools have not provided U.S. News with enough information to make an accurate calculation. In these instances, schools are omitted from the results and are not given a My Fit score.

6. Does the U.S. News My Fit tool work for graduate schools?

At this time, the U.S. News My Fit tool only focuses on traditional undergraduate schools.

7. What if I have some suggestions or questions not answered here?

Please email usnewscollegecompass@usnews.com for customer support.

8. Why am I seeing a U.S. News My Fit gauge on college and university pages?

Once you put your information into the U.S. News My Fit tool, each time you visit a school's page on usnews.com, the My Fit gauge will appear, showing your My Fit score.

Disclaimer

Results from the U.S. News My Fit tool in no way guarantee or suggest that you will be accepted or rejected from a college, university or program. The results are based on information you provide and information that U.S. News has obtained through our higher education surveys.

The U.S. News My Fit tool must only be used as a guide and should not be the only determining factor for selecting a college, university or program. There are many other factors that are important in making a higher education decision, many of which are not reflected in this tool.

U.S. News reserves the right to modify or update the U.S. News My Fit tool at any time.

Use of this tool is subject to the [U.S. News Terms and Conditions](#) and [Privacy Policy](#).

Frequently Asked Questions: U.S. News College Compass

Find answers to common questions about the comprehensive college search tool.

1. What do I get when I purchase the [U.S. News College Compass](#)?

You will get access to the full [Best Colleges](#) rankings, comprehensive information on each school, and premium tools and features. Subscribing to College Compass unlocks:

- The My Fit custom ranking experience: Build a customized ranking based on your personal preferences, view a school's My Fit score in our compare tool, add new preferences and more.
- Application management: Track your college applications, see which phase of the process you're in for each school and check off tasks as you complete them.
- A free electronic edition of the U.S. News Path to College Guidebook
- Premium data in the college compare tool
- More than 30 additional premium rankings available only to Compass subscribers
- Expanded school profiles, with more than 500,000 additional data points
- Ability to save schools and take notes on them
- Detailed test score and financial aid information
- Advanced search options

Try our [My Fit custom ranking demo](#), which lets you explore some available criteria filters and see the number of schools that fit you.

2. How long is my U.S. News College Compass subscription valid?

Your subscription is valid for one year from the purchase date.

3. What browser should I use to access the U.S. News College Compass?

For the best experience browsing usnews.com, use the current and prior major versions of Chrome, Mozilla Firefox or Safari.

4. What system requirements do I need to log in?

A browser with JavaScript and cookies enabled is required. See above for recommended browsers.

5. Can I access the U.S. News College Compass on more than one computer?

You can access the U.S. News College Compass on more than one machine without an additional charge. Please note, however, that access is for individual use only, and you cannot share your password with

anyone. Significant use of a single password on multiple computers could result in suspension of that password.

If you are working on a shared machine, such as a computer in a library or university lab, you should click the "Logout" link when you are finished.

6. What is your cancellation policy?

If you are not satisfied with the U.S. News College Compass, you may cancel your subscription within the first 24 hours of purchase, and we will refund your fee. To cancel your subscription, please contact usnewscollegecompass@usnews.com.

7. I have specific questions about the U.S. News My Fit tool. Where can I get help?

Please see the [U.S. News My Fit FAQ](#).

8. I can't find the solution to my problem here. How can I contact you for more help?

Please contact usnewscollegecompass@usnews.com with any remaining questions.

Why U.S. News Ranks the Best Colleges and Universities

Investment in a college education may profoundly affect your job opportunities and quality of life.

By Robert Morse

Why does U.S. News & World Report rank [colleges and universities](#)? It's a controversial question with a simple answer: U.S. News does it to help you make one of the most important decisions of your life.

Your investment in a college education could profoundly affect your career opportunities, how much money you earn (i.e., your earning power) and your quality of life. Based on recent data from the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS), one thing is clear: education pays. College graduates and professionals with advanced degrees make more money and tend to have lower instances of unemployment.

See this [chart](#) on unemployment rates and earnings by level of educational attainment. It uses data from the U.S. Census Bureau, U.S. Department of Labor and BLS to show workers' median weekly earnings and unemployment rates in 2023, both broken down by level of educational attainment.

The figures in this chart dramatically show the value of earning a bachelor's degree or a graduate degree. Workers with bachelor's degrees earn a median of \$1,493 per week, which is 66% more weekly income than those with just a high school diploma. The income disparity is even greater when you compare earnings of those with master's, doctoral or professional degrees with earnings of those whose highest education level is high school or those who didn't finish high school. For example, those with a master's degree earn 1.9 times as much per week (\$1,737) as those whose highest degree is a high school diploma (\$899). In addition, a doctor or lawyer with a professional degree earns 2.5 times as much money per week (\$2,206) as those whose highest education level is a high school diploma.

The analysis also points out another key truism, which is that unemployment is linked to your level of educational attainment. Even in eras of relatively low unemployment, the higher the level of education achieved, the lower the unemployment rate is for that group. In other words, people with doctorates or professional degrees in fields such as medicine or law have far lower unemployment rates than those who didn't finish high school or didn't finish any college.

Whatever degree you decide to pursue, choosing the right college is a huge first step.

To [find the right college](#), you need a source of comprehensive data – information that lets you compare one school with another and find the differences that matter to you. That's what U.S. News' Best Colleges rankings are for.

U.S. News ranks for best quality as well as for [best value](#). You wouldn't buy a computer, cellphone or car without making sure it was the best you could afford, given your budget. The same rule should apply in choosing a college – especially when four years at some private U.S. universities can cost more than \$370,000 in tuition, food and housing, fees, books, and other personal expenses for those paying the full sticker price. Know that many students at expensive schools qualify for need-based financial aid, and many

pay far less than the sticker price. Students at some schools also receive merit-based scholarships that can greatly reduce the price, too.

Most people choose a college only once in their lifetime, so you need first-rate information from the start. The 2025 edition of the Best Colleges rankings, in print and online, can help you by making it easier to sift through data from more than 1,800 colleges and universities.

Here's how:

- Use the rankings as a tool to select and compare schools.
- Use the search and sort capabilities of the rankings to learn more about different types of schools.
- Think long and hard about the right place for you and choose carefully.
- Don't wait until the last minute. College matters.
- Don't rely solely on rankings as the basis for choosing a college.

Students should gather information on colleges in a number of ways – by talking to parents, high school guidance counselors and other advisers; from college catalogs, books and websites; and from [campus visits](#) to form firsthand impressions.

Think of the rankings as one tool for selecting a college. U.S. News recognizes that prospective students must consider their academic and professional goals, [financial resources](#), scholastic record, and personal needs when choosing a school.

How to Use the Best Colleges Rankings Wisely

Students should use the U.S. News rankings as just one tool in their college search process.

By Robert Morse and Eric Brooks

The 2025 edition of the U.S. News & World Report [Best Colleges](#) rankings provides an ideal starting point for families comparing colleges. It offers an opportunity to judge the relative quality of the educational experience at schools according to widely accepted indicators of excellence.

Many other factors, including some that can't be measured, should figure into your decision – such as the school's cost, availability of [financial aid](#), course offerings, activities, the feel of campus life and the geographic location. [College visits](#), if possible, can prove invaluable, too.

How should families use the various rankings tables and lists on usnews.com? Study the data that accompanies the actual rankings. You should not use the rankings as the sole basis for deciding on one school over another. The rankings are a source of useful comparative information about colleges that might otherwise be hard to obtain and can help you [narrow your search](#) to a small number of colleges that are a good fit.

For instance, high school students can scan the student [SAT or ACT scores](#) at different institutions to infer whether they could gain admission to a particular college – and even rise to the top of the applicant pool and possibly qualify for a [merit-based scholarship](#).

They can use class size data to get a sense of the intimacy of classes, and they can use the acceptance rate to gauge their odds of getting into a given school.

They can check student-faculty ratios to see how much attention they are likely to receive from professors at different schools or check first-year student retention rates to learn how hard schools work to keep students from dropping out after the first year. They can also study graduation rates, which are the single best indicator of the proportion of first-year students who graduate with a bachelor's degree from a school.

They can study other lists to see how the [public schools](#) stack up against one another, to compare specialty schools, or to see how U.S. News rates campuses in terms of [ethnic diversity](#) or [best value](#) for the dollar. And students can look up more than 1,800 four-year schools in the U.S. News directory to gather information on each school's location, size, cost, academic offerings and financial aid policies.

While scanning U.S. News' lists to find colleges that could be a good fit, students and parents may find many institutions that they had not considered – or even heard of. There are hundreds of fine colleges and universities, and ultimately the challenge is to narrow the list to a few that the student would really like to attend.

The advice and rankings on this site will give students the names of some of those schools and help them think more about which colleges make the most sense for them. Good luck.

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Embargoed – Subject to Change

Best Colleges Rankings Information for School Officials

Find out how university officials can display badges, report data changes and more.

The information presented in the 2025 U.S. News & World Report [Best Colleges](#) rankings and directory was collected during the spring and summer of 2024 via U.S. News' annual online statistical surveys of colleges.

Before contacting U.S. News to request a change to the directory or other college data, please contact your school's institutional research office or the equivalent office on your campus that fills out external surveys to coordinate a change request. The person(s) who completed the annual Best Colleges statistical survey should then review the data in question and, if necessary, contact us to request a change.

For schools that didn't respond to the U.S. News 2024 survey, data collected in previous years from those schools or from publicly available third-party sources, such as the U.S. Department of Education's [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System](#) (IPEDS) or the department's College Scorecard, is used in their online profiles on usnews.com.

Requests for data changes: Change requests must be submitted using the actual survey page on which the data in question appears. Mark the correction, scan the corrected page and email a PDF to usnews-data-collection@usnews.com. Requests received on forms other than the actual survey page will not be processed.

Updating the online directory and other college data once the surveys have gone through the verification process is time-consuming. Corrections normally take about four to eight weeks to implement. We appreciate your patience.

Requests for unpublished Best Colleges ranking information: Schools in the ranking range in any ranking can obtain their actual ranking in the range by emailing usnews-data-collection@usnews.com. Please specify which ranking list(s) you are inquiring about. U.S. News will accept these requests for actual rankings in the ranking range only from the following university officials: the director of admissions, the director of financial aid, the head of public relations, the head of institutional research, the U.S. News statistical survey respondents, the president's office or the provost's office. Only unpublished rankings from the current 2025 edition and the 2024 edition are available.

Other Best Colleges data, methodology and rankings questions: Email official@usnews.com.

Access to historical benchmarking and unpublished Best Colleges rankings data: U.S. News' Academic Insights is a performance assessment tool that houses more than 30 years of historical U.S. News rankings. Containing both published and unpublished data, the platform provides raw data and visualization tools to help process and track changes in thousands of metrics across various program areas. Institutional researchers, campus leadership and policymakers use Academic Insights to help make informed, data-driven decisions on college, university and high school campuses across the country. For more information, please email academicinsights@usnews.com.

Badges and advertising information: For most ranking categories, schools that are highly ranked will be eligible to display a trademarked U.S. News Best Colleges badge. School officials can review the [list of badge-eligible schools](#) in each category to determine their eligibility. U.S. News' exclusive licensing agent, BrandConnex, handles licensing of badges to eligible schools.

For more information about obtaining and using U.S. News badge(s) in promotional efforts, please contact BrandConnex at usnews@brandconnex.com. Purchase of a badge will not affect current or future rankings.

To advertise with U.S. News, contact Shannon Tkach at stkach@usnews.com or 202-955-2134.

"Best Colleges 2025" guidebooks or custom reprints: To order a copy of the "Best Colleges 2025" guidebook, call 800-836-6397 or visit usnews.com/collegeguide. For discounts on bulk orders of 25 or more copies, please contact booksales@usnews.com.

Additional marketing opportunities:

- **U.S. News Student Connect** is an audience engagement solution that gives schools direct access to their audience, brand engagement and messaging on usnews.com. To learn more, please contact Shannon Tkach at stkach@usnews.com or 202-955-2134.
- **Submit photos of campus** to showcase your school year-round on usnews.com. More than 1,200 schools have added photos to their U.S. News directory pages, giving students and parents a better feel for their institutions. Our free, easy-to-use photo tool allows you to include up to 25 photos. Contact schoolphotos@usnews.com to get started.

To learn about additional marketing opportunities with U.S. News, please visit our [School Marketing Center](#).